

74 busy book activities

Toddler Busy Book

Matching, sorting, colors, shapes, pretend play, first words and mazes, sorted by age, with a “talk while you play” line on every page.



 1–2 years

 2–3 years

 3–5 years

49 no-cut pages • 0-minute prep

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Parent education

This book is parent education and play ideas. It is not medical, developmental or professional advice and doesn't diagnose, treat or prevent anything. Every play follows our published safety rules (page 7); a grown-up is always part of play.

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Version 1.0 · September 2026. If we improve this file, we'll tell past buyers what changed; we never swap a file quietly.



Play Before Pixels

Play Before Pixels makes calm, paper-first play for families: talk, touch and play first; fewer screens, more back-and-forth.

Play today in four steps

Prep time: **0 minutes** for 49 pages (print and play). **5–10 minutes** for pages with pieces: straight cuts only, 12 pieces or fewer per sheet. No page takes longer to prep than it plays.

1 Find your child's age band

Pages are sorted by age. Ages are starting points, not deadlines: move up or down whenever you like.

● 1–2 years · pages 19–45

● 2–3 years · pages 46–78

● 3–5 years · pages 79–118

2 Print one no-cut page and play

Good first pages: **1–2**: “ball” (p.21), Who says “moo”? (p.25), Peekaboo house (p.40) · **2–3**: Color hunt in the park (p.53), Beep beep! Drive to the park (p.76), One, two, three (p.73) · **3–5**: Help Duck get to the pond (p.80), Blast off to the moon (p.105), Which one is different? (p.97).

3 Cut pieces when you have ten minutes

Each piece sheet sits right after its activity page. Cut on the straight dashed lines, count the pieces into a pouch, and the grown-up keeps the pouch. Laminating and velcro are optional (tips on page 9).

4 Talk while you play

Every page has one line to say out loud. That line is the heart of the book. Read the 2-page grown-up guide next (pages 4–5).

74

activities in 3 age bands

49

no-cut pages, ready today

23

piece sheets · 157 pieces, all 2 in or bigger

132

pages in all, US Letter and A4

Inside too: binder covers in 4 colors, spine and pouch labels, a weekly busy-book planner (Monday and Sunday starts, pre-filled and blank), make-your-own pages you can type into, a Busy Book Star certificate, an answer key and quick answers. **Color and Low-ink files** are included: Low-ink prints on white with colorable line art.

What you need today

- A printer and plain paper or cardstock
- A grown-up and a child, side by side
- That's it for the 49 no-cut pages

Nice to have later

- Scissors or a paper trimmer (straight cuts only)
- Sheet protectors or a laminator, a binder and zip pouches
- Velcro dots, for the 3–5 pages only

Why busy-book play?

Little ones learn words from the people who talk and play with them. A busy book gives the two of you something to point at, name and move around, so the talk comes easily. You don't need a plan or a script; the pages give you one.

2-minute setup

1. Print one page. Cutting can wait.
2. Sit side by side or with your child on your lap.
3. Let your child touch, point and choose first.
4. Say the "talk while you play" line, then pause.
5. Stop while it's still fun. Short is perfect.

Most children love 2–3 of these

You don't need all 74. Most children find two or three favorites and want them again and again. That's not boring for them: repeating is how play grows. Rotate a few pages each week and keep the rest for later.

Three talk lines that work on any page

SAY WHAT YOU SEE

"Big red apple!"

Name what your child is looking at, in a few words.

PAUSE AND WAIT

"Ready, set... (wait)"

Count to five in your head. Give your child room to take a turn.

ADD ONE WORD

"Duck." → "Yellow duck!"

Repeat what your child says and add one word.

Every turn counts

Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. A sign, a point, a look, a sound or a device tap all count as a turn. There's no right answer on any page: if your child calls the frog a "duck," say "A green frog! Ribbit!" and keep playing.

Every way of playing counts

Lining pieces up, playing the same page again and again, moving around, humming, or playing side by side instead of face to face: it's all play. Eye contact is never needed. If your child says no or walks away, stop and try another day.

Big kids can help

Brothers, sisters and cousins about 6 and up make great helpers: they can read the talk line out loud, run the café or deliver the mail. A grown-up stays right there and keeps the pieces.

How the book works

1–2 years

Little hands

Point, name, pat and place. Big pictures, big pieces, lots of repeating.

22 activities, 18 with no cutting.

2–3 years

Busy explorers

Match, sort and pretend. Colors, shapes, pairs and first little stories.

23 activities, 14 with no cutting.

3–5 years

Big thinkers

Mazes, counting, patterns, sequencing and bigger pretend play.

29 activities, 17 with no cutting.

Six talk moves you'll see on the pages

Say what you see. Name it in a few words.

Pause and wait. Leave a gap for their turn.

Repeat and add one word. Say it back, one step bigger.

Offer a choice. "This or that?" A point is an answer.

Follow their lead. Talk about what they're into.

Sing and gesture. Tunes and moves make words stick.

Make it easier, make it harder

Every page has both, so one page grows with your child. If a page is a struggle, pick "easier" or save it for later. If it's too easy, try "harder," or move to the next band.

The tired-grown-up version

Every page has a 2-minute version with no setup, for days when you have nothing left. Two minutes of play together still counts.

A good fit for screen-free moments

Waiting for dinner, a rainy afternoon, a slow morning, a doctor's waiting room: pick a page, sit together and play. Nothing to charge, nothing to switch off.

Every child grows at their own pace. The ages in this book are starting points, not deadlines, and no page is a test. If you have questions about your child's development, your pediatrician is the best person to ask. This book is parent education and play ideas, not medical or developmental advice.

Every page works the same way

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

1-2 years

MATCHING

Cut pieces on page 29

Same, same! Toys

Match picture to picture. Hand over one big card. Show how to lay it on its twin, then let them try.



ball



cup



shoe



book

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Ball! Same ball. Ball on ball!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Use two cards only, and place the first one together.

MAKE IT HARDER

Lay out all four cards and ask for one by name: "Where's the cup?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Place one card on its twin. Clap. Done.

1-2 years · from 15 months

Prep: 5 min

Mess: None

Needs: Scissors, cardstock

Play together, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps the pieces and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Play Before Pixels · Toddler Busy Book

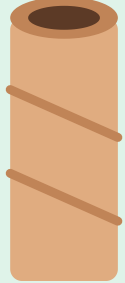
Version 1.0 · September 2026 · © 2026 AlphaPlay LLC

- 1 Age band and starting age.** A color and a word label, so you never rely on color alone.
- 2 Cut or no-cut.** No-cut pages are ready today. Cut pages point to their piece sheet.
- 3 Title and how to play.** One or two sentences. That's all the instructions you need.
- 4 The play area.** Big, calm pictures for your child to point at, pat and place pieces on.
- 5 Talk while you play.** One line to say out loud, and the talk move it uses.
- 6 Easier, harder, tired version.** Three ways to play the same page, including a 2-minute one.
- 7 Prep, mess, needs, safety.** Honest prep time, what you need and the safety note for this page.

Piece sheets come right after their activity page. Each piece shows the page it belongs to in its corner (for example "p.28"), so strays always find their way home.

Our play safety rules

Every page in this book follows these rules. Please read them once before you start.



The toilet-paper-tube test

For children under 3, nothing small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm across). **Every cut piece in this book is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger** on its shortest side, and the pieces for 1–2 years are 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger.

Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in. Store them in a pouch or envelope that the grown-up keeps. Throw away any piece that tears, bends, gets wet or peels.

Always together

Every activity is played with a grown-up right there. Read together and keep paper and pieces away from mouths.

Velcro rules

No loose velcro dots for under-3s: for 1–2 and 2–3 pages, lay pieces on top. For 3–5 pages velcro is optional: **check dots before each play** and keep pieces away from younger children.

Laminated edges

Leave a small border when you cut laminated pieces and round the corners so edges stay soft.

Crayons and pens

Dry-erase crayons are for the 3–5 pages, with a grown-up. The grown-up keeps caps, which are small.

Pretend food only

The food pages are pictures. No real food is part of any activity, and none of the pictured foods are small, hard or round snacks.

Nothing else to add

No balloons, beads, buttons, coins, strings or cords are used or needed anywhere in this book.

Real toys? A few pages suggest a real toy (a ball, a toy car, a box). For under-3s, any real toy must pass the tube test and have no small parts that come off. If you're ever unsure, leave it out: the page works without it.

Grown-up tools. Scissors, the paper trimmer and the laminator (it gets hot) are for grown-ups. Plastic zip pouches, sheet protectors and laminating scraps stay out of reach: plastic isn't a toy.

Build your busy book three ways

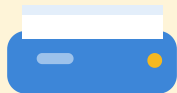
Pick the one that fits your week. You can start with the quick one today and upgrade later.



Quick: no laminator

1. Print pages on cardstock (or plain paper).
2. Slide each page into a clear sheet protector.
3. Keep pages in a 1–1.5 in 3-ring binder.
4. Pieces go in a zip pouch clipped to the binder.

About 15 minutes for 10 pages.



Classic: laminated

1. Print on cardstock and laminate (3–5 mil pouches).
2. Cut pieces with a small clear border; round corners.
3. Punch holes and use binder rings or a binder.
4. One labeled pouch per piece sheet.

Pieces last for months of play.



Velcro: ages 3–5 only

1. Laminate first, then add dots.
 2. Soft (loop) dot on the page, scratchy (hook) dot on the piece.
 3. Press firmly; let dots set overnight.
 4. Check dots before each play.
- No velcro for under-3s.

Use only for the 3–5 pages.

Handy supplies

- Cardstock, 65–110 lb (176–300 gsm)
- Scissors or a paper trimmer (straight cuts only)
- Sheet protectors or a laminator (optional)
- Binder or binder rings, and zip pouches
- Velcro dots for the 3–5 pages (optional)

Organize by age

Use one binder cover per child or per age band (4 colors on pages 13–16). Tape a pouch label to each pouch (page 18). Keep 5–8 pages in the binder and rotate the rest each week with the planner on page 124.

Make it last

Laminating

- Use 3–5 mil pouches. Thicker pouches make stiffer pieces that little hands grip easily.
- Laminate the whole sheet first, then cut. Leave about 1/8 in (3 mm) of clear border so the seal holds.
- Round every corner with scissors or a corner rounder.
- No laminator? Clear sheet protectors work for pages; packing tape over both sides works for a few pieces.
- Wipe pages with a damp cloth. Let them dry flat.

Velcro (3–5 pages only)

- Soft “loop” dots go on the page; scratchy “hook” dots go on the back of pieces.
- Put the dot in the middle of the slot so pieces sit straight.
- Press for 30 seconds and let dots set overnight before play.
- **Check dots before each play.** Throw away any piece whose dot lifts at the edge.
- **Never** on 1–2 or 2–3 pages: lay those pieces on top instead.

Dry-erase

Mazes and road pages work with a dry-erase crayon on laminated pages. Wipe with a dry cloth. The grown-up keeps caps.

Storage

One zip pouch per piece sheet, labeled with its page number. Every piece also shows its page in the corner.

Save ink

Print the Low-ink file for pages you want to color, and for piece sheets you’ll laminate anyway.

Worn out? That means it was loved. Reprint just that page: the files are yours to print again for your own home.

Print only what you need

Pick your file

- **US Letter** (8.5 × 11 in) or **A4** (210 × 297 mm): same pages, same piece sizes.
- **Color** for bright pages. **Low-ink** for white pages with colorable line art.
- The make-your-own pages can be typed into in a free PDF reader before printing.

Printer settings

- Print at **100% / actual size**. “Fit to page” shrinks pieces.
- Single-sided only: pieces and pages need blank backs.
- Print a page range (for example 19–27) instead of the whole book.

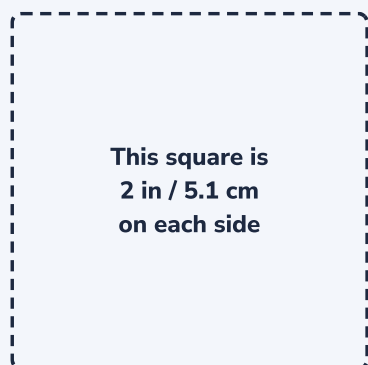
Paper

Cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) for pieces and anything you’ll handle a lot. Plain paper is fine for no-cut pages in sheet protectors.

Home or print shop

Home printers are perfect. For a sturdy set, a local print shop can print on cardstock and laminate; take the file on a USB stick and ask for “actual size.”

Check your size



Measure this square after printing. If it’s smaller than 2 in (5.1 cm), your printer is scaling the page: choose 100% or actual size and print again. The pieces rely on it.

Every activity, by age

Tick the pages you've played. Draw a star by the favorites.

1–2 years • Little hands

☐	20	First words: “hi” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	21	First words: “ball” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	22	First words: “up” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	23	First words: “cup” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	24	First words: “shoe” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	25	Who says “moo”? Animal sounds • no cut • from 12 months
☐	26	Who says “woof”? Animal sounds • no cut • from 12 months
☐	27	Peekaboo, duck! Look & find • no cut • from 15 months
☐	28	Same, same! Toys Matching • cut p.29 • from 15 months
☐	30	Same, same! Animals Matching • cut p.31 • from 15 months
☐	32	Drum along! Sing & move • no cut • from 12 months
☐	33	Big and little Big & little • no cut • from 18 months
☐	34	Lunch for Teddy Pretend play • cut p.35 • from 18 months
☐	36	Red, yellow, blue, green Colors • cut p.37 • from 20 months
☐	38	Where’s your nose? First words • no cut • from 15 months
☐	39	Pick a song Sing & move • no cut • from 12 months
☐	40	Peekaboo house Look & find • no cut • from 12 months
☐	41	First words: “book” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	42	First words: “more” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	43	First words: “uh-oh” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	44	First words: “bye-bye” First words • no cut • from 12 months
☐	45	First words: “night-night” First words • no cut • from 12 months

2–3 years • Busy explorers

☐	47	First words: “go” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	48	First words: “stop” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	49	First words: “down” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	50	First words: “in” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	51	Color sort Colors • cut p.52 • from 24 months
☐	53	Color hunt in the park Colors • no cut • from 24 months
☐	54	Shape match Shapes • cut p.55 • from 26 months
☐	56	Shapes everywhere Shapes • no cut • from 28 months
☐	57	Shadow match Matching • cut p.58 • from 28 months
☐	59	Big or small? Sorting • cut p.60 • from 26 months
☐	61	Dress for the weather Pretend play • cut p.62 • from 28 months
☐	63	Pizza shop Pretend play • cut p.64 • from 28 months
☐	65	Same feeling Feelings • cut p.66 • from 30 months
☐	67	In, on, under First words • no cut • from 30 months
☐	68	First words: “open” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	69	First words: “help” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	70	Who lives here? Matching • cut p.71 • from 30 months
☐	72	Opposites Big & little • no cut • from 30 months
☐	73	One, two, three Counting • no cut • from 30 months
☐	74	Find the pair Matching • cut p.75 • from 30 months
☐	76	Beep beep! Drive to the park Pretend play • no cut • from 24 months
☐	77	First words: “clap” First words • no cut • from 24 months
☐	78	First words: “all done” First words • no cut • from 24 months

Every activity, by age

3–5 years · Big thinkers

☐	80	Help Duck get to the pond Mazes · 1 of 8 · no cut · from 3 years
☐	81	Help Dog get home Mazes · 2 of 8 · no cut · from 3 years
☐	82	Help Bee find the flower Mazes · 3 of 8 · no cut · from 40 months
☐	83	Drive the car home Mazes · 4 of 8 · no cut · from 42 months
☐	84	How many? Match 1 to 6 Counting · cut p.85 · from 3 years
☐	86	Count in the garden Counting · no cut · from 40 months
☐	87	What comes next? Patterns · cards p.89 · from 42 months
☐	88	What comes next? Tricky ones Patterns · cut p.89 · from 4 years
☐	90	First, next, last Little stories · cards p.92 · from 42 months
☐	91	First, next, last: more stories Little stories · cut p.92 · from 44 months
☐	93	Swim, Fish, swim! Mazes · 5 of 8 · no cut · from 44 months
☐	94	Fly Bird to the nest Mazes · 6 of 8 · no cut · from 4 years
☐	95	Small, medium, big Sorting · cut p.96 · from 38 months
☐	97	Which one is different? Look & find · no cut · from 40 months

☐	98	Spot 4 differences Look & find · no cut · from 44 months
☐	99	Shopping trip Pretend play · cut p.100 · from 3 years
☐	101	Post office Pretend play · cut p.102 · from 40 months
☐	103	Our café Pretend play · cut p.104 · from 3 years
☐	105	Blast off to the moon Pretend play · no cut · from 3 years
☐	106	Drive around town Pretend play · no cut · from 3 years
☐	107	Rocket to the moon Mazes · 7 of 8 · no cut · from 54 months
☐	108	Rhyme time Rhymes · cut p.109 · from 42 months
☐	110	Where does it go? Sorting · cut p.111 · from 40 months
☐	112	How do they feel? Feelings · no cut · from 3 years
☐	113	Finish the picture Matching · cut p.114 · from 42 months
☐	115	I spy at the pond Look & find · no cut · from 3 years
☐	116	Wiggly road Mazes · roads · no cut · from 3 years
☐	117	Zig-zag mountain road Mazes · roads · no cut · from 40 months
☐	118	Teddy's long way to bed Mazes · 8 of 8 · no cut · from 54 months

Also inside

13–18	Binder covers (4 colors), spine and pouch labels
119–123	Make your own pages (fillable)
124–127	Weekly busy-book planner (Monday and Sunday starts)
128	Busy Book Star certificate
129	Answer key
130	Quick answers

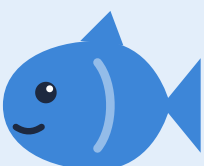
my
Busy Book



THIS BUSY BOOK BELONGS TO

Type a name here before printing, or write it by hand.

my
Busy Book



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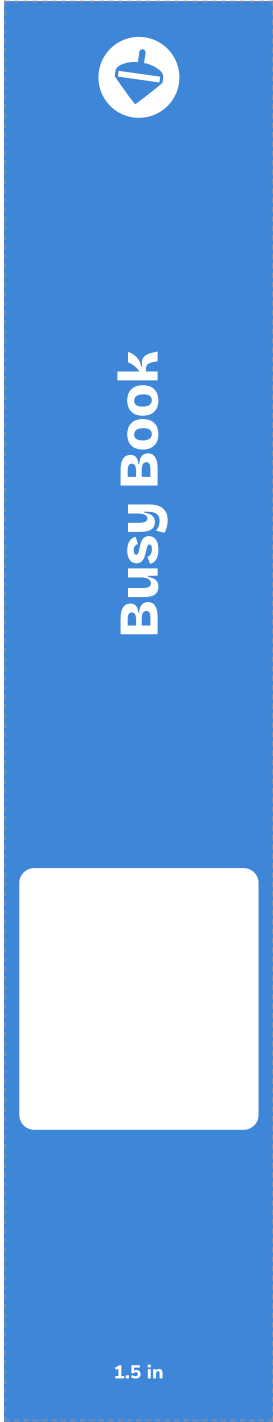
Type a name here before printing, or write it by hand.

Binder spine labels

Cut the strip that fits your binder spine: 1 in, 1.5 in or 2 in. Type a name in the white box first if you like.



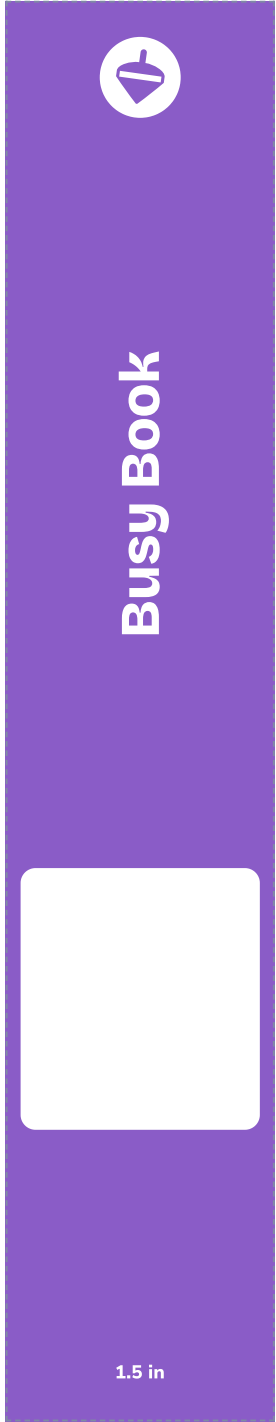
1 in



1.5 in



2 in



1.5 in

Pouch labels

One label per pouch of pieces. Type or write the page number and name, then tape the label to a zip pouch. Each label is 3.5 × 2 in.

Pieces for page Pieces: Grown-up keeps these	Pieces for page Pieces: Grown-up keeps these
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1–2 years

Little hands

Point, name, pat and place. Big pictures, big pieces, lots of repeating.



What this age often loves

- Pointing, patting and “again!”
- Animal sounds and silly voices
- One big picture at a time
- Songs with moves
- Hiding and finding (peekaboo!)

In this section

22 activities · 18 no-cut pages · starting from 12 months.

Start with whatever your child is into today. Skip anything that isn't fun yet, and come back later.

Every child grows at their own pace. Ages are starting points, not deadlines. Questions about your child's development? Your pediatrician is the best person to ask.

First words: "hi"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Wave hello!

hi



ACT IT Wave hello!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Hi! (wave... and wait) Hi, hi!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Just wave and smile. A look back counts as a turn.

MAKE IT HARDER

Say hi to everyone in the picture, then to a toy, then to the mirror.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Wave at the page, then at each other. That's it.

📍 **1-2 years** · from 12 months ⌚ **Prep: 0 min** 💧 **Mess: None** 🛒 **Needs: Just this page**

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "ball"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Bounce, bounce, boing!

ball



SAY IT Bounce, bounce, boing!

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Ball! Big ball. Roll, ball!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Hold a real ball next to the picture and say "ball."

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask "Where's the ball?" and wait for a point.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Point, say "ball," roll a real ball once. Done.

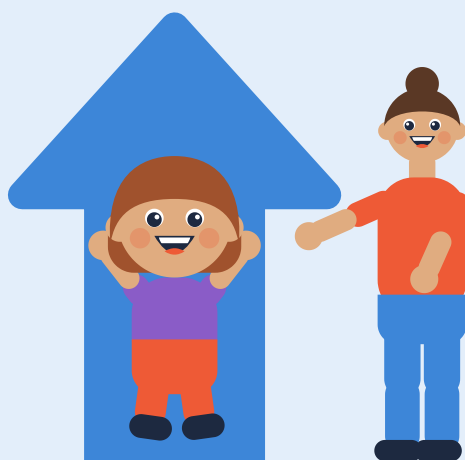
📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: “up”

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Reach your arms up high.

up



ACT IT Reach your arms up high

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

“Up... up... (wait) UP!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Lift your own arms and say it. Your child just watches.

MAKE IT HARDER

Stop before “up!” and let them fill the gap with any sound.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Reach up high together three times.

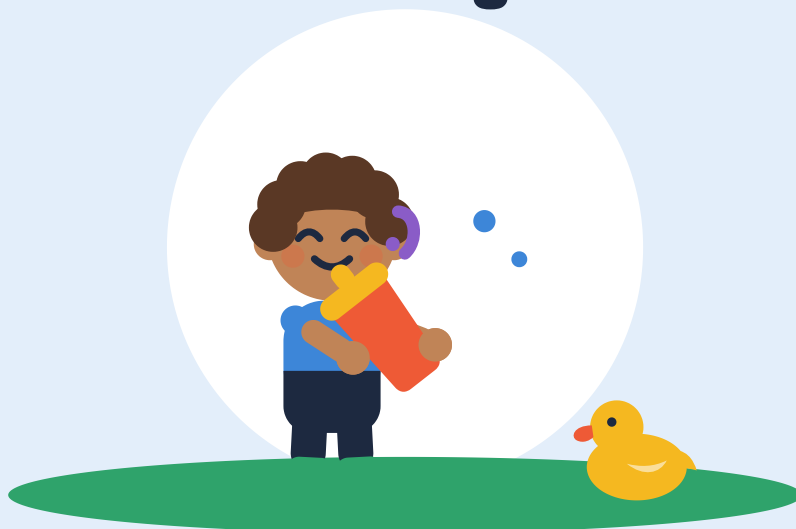
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✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "cup"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Sip, sip... ahh!

cup



SAY IT Sip, sip... ahh!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Cup. Your cup. Sip, sip... ahh!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Hold their real cup next to the picture.

MAKE IT HARDER

Offer a choice: "Blue cup or red cup?" A point is an answer.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Pretend to sip from the picture. "Ahh!"

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "shoe"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Stomp, stomp your feet.

shoe



ACT IT Stomp, stomp your feet



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"Shoe! Where's your shoe? Shoe on!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Touch the picture, then touch their shoe.

MAKE IT HARDER

Find two real shoes and say "two shoes!"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Stomp, stomp your feet together.

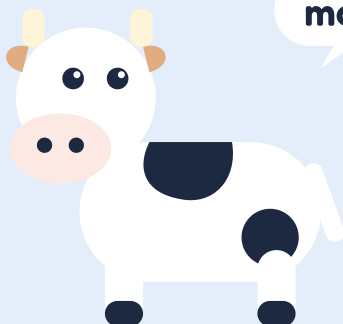
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✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

Who says “moo”?

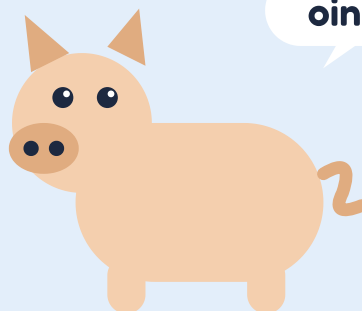
Point and moo. Point to an animal, make its sound, then wait. Any sound back is a turn, even a squeal.

cow



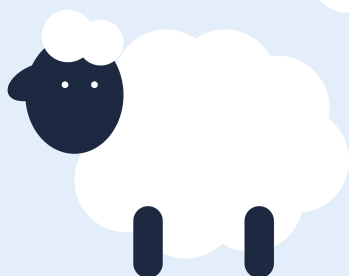
moo!

pig



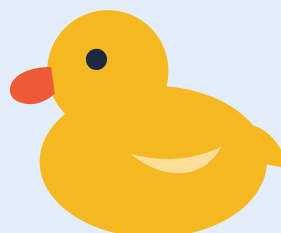
oink!

sheep



baa!

duck



quack!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

“The cow says... (wait) MOO!”**MAKE IT EASIER**

Make the sound for them and pat the picture.

MAKE IT HARDER

Say the sound first and let them find the animal.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

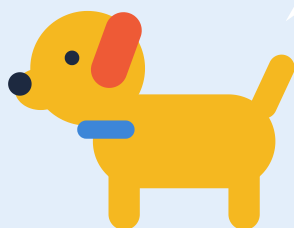
Pick one animal. Make its sound three times. Done.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

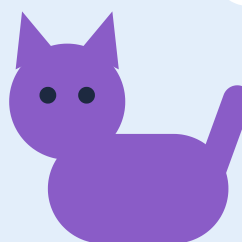
Who says “woof”?

Point and play. Name the animal, make its sound, and add a move: pant like the dog, hop like the frog.



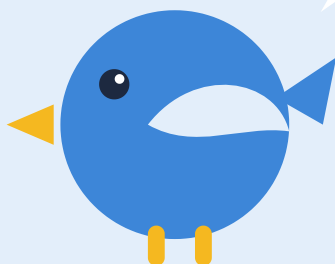
woof!

dog



meow!

cat



tweet!

bird



ribbit!

frog



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

“Woof woof! Dog says woof. Hop, hop, ribbit!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Just the sounds, nice and slow.

MAKE IT HARDER

Mix them up: “Does the cat say woof?”
Silly questions make great talk.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

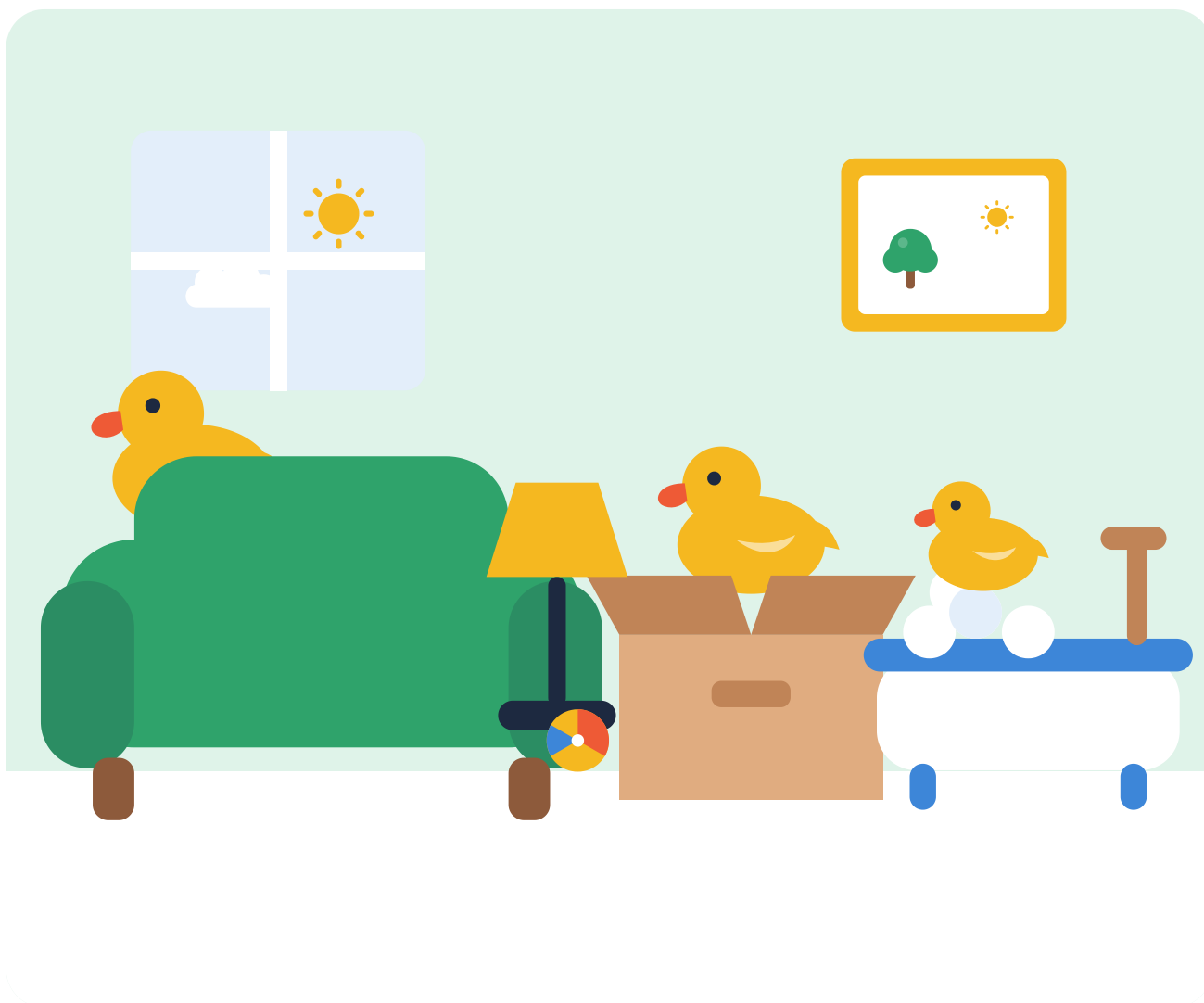
Hop like the frog once. Ribbit!

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📦 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Peekaboo, duck!

Find the ducks. Three ducks are hiding. Ask “Where’s duck?” and let your child find them, with a point or a pat.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

“There’s duck! Duck is in the bath. Peekaboo, duck!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Point to one duck and say “there’s duck!” together.

MAKE IT HARDER

Count the ducks with a finger: one, two, three.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Find one duck. Say “peekaboo!” Done.

📍 1-2 years · from 15 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🧰 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Same, same! Toys

Match picture to picture. Hand over one big card. Show how to lay it on its twin, then let them try.



ball



cup



shoe



book



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Ball! Same ball. Ball on ball!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Use two cards only, and place the first one together.

MAKE IT HARDER

Lay out all four cards and ask for one by name: "Where's the cup?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

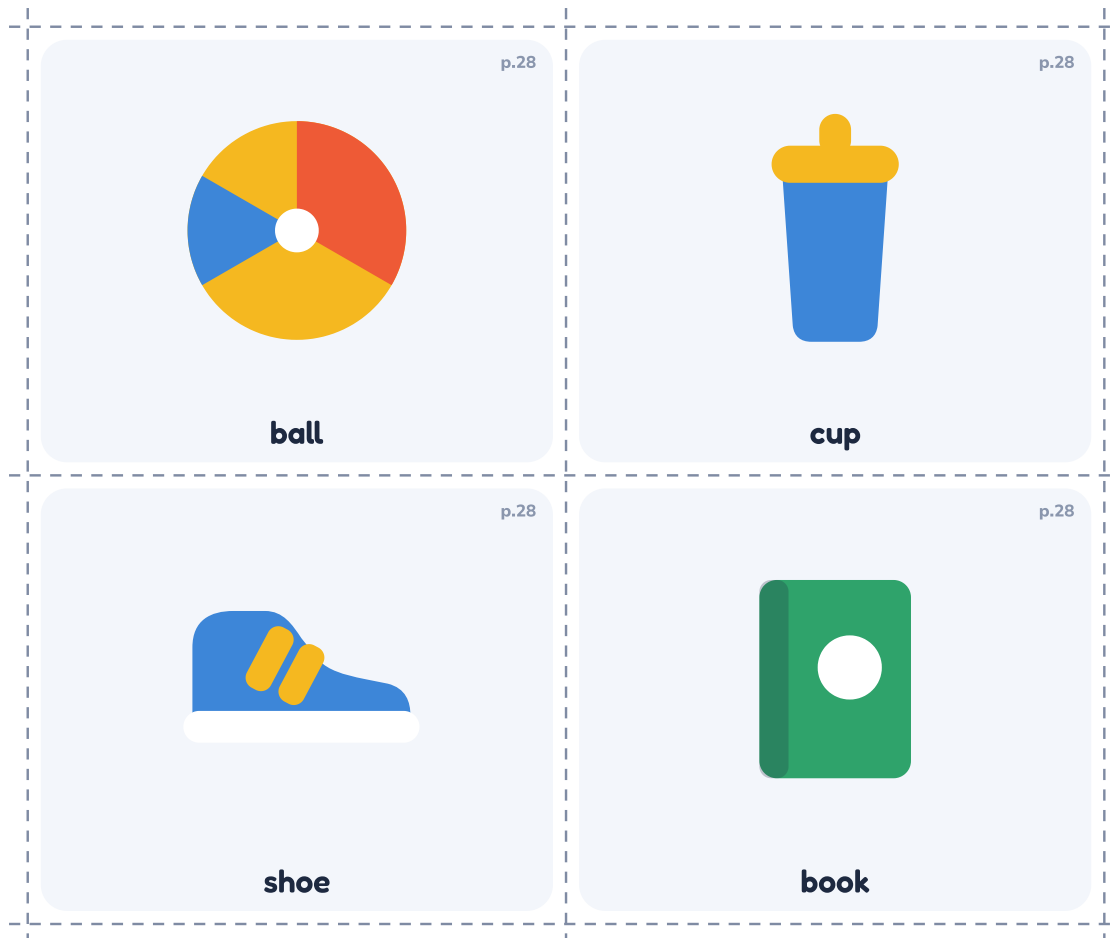
Place one card on its twin. Clap. Done.

📍 **1-2 years** · from 15 months ⌚ **Prep: 5 min** 💧 **Mess: None** 🛠 **Needs: Scissors, cardstock**

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 28: Same, same! Toys

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Same, same! Animals

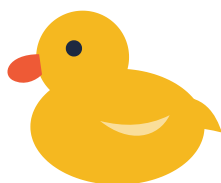
Match and make the sound. Each time a card lands on its twin, make that animal's sound together.



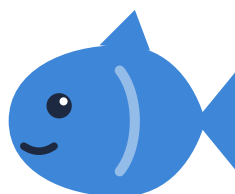
dog



cat



duck



fish



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Dog on dog! The dog says... (wait) woof!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Start with the duck and dog only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Turn cards face down and flip one:
"Who is it?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Make one animal sound, place one card.
Done.

📍 1-2 years · from 15 months ⌚ Prep: 5 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 30: Same, same! Animals

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



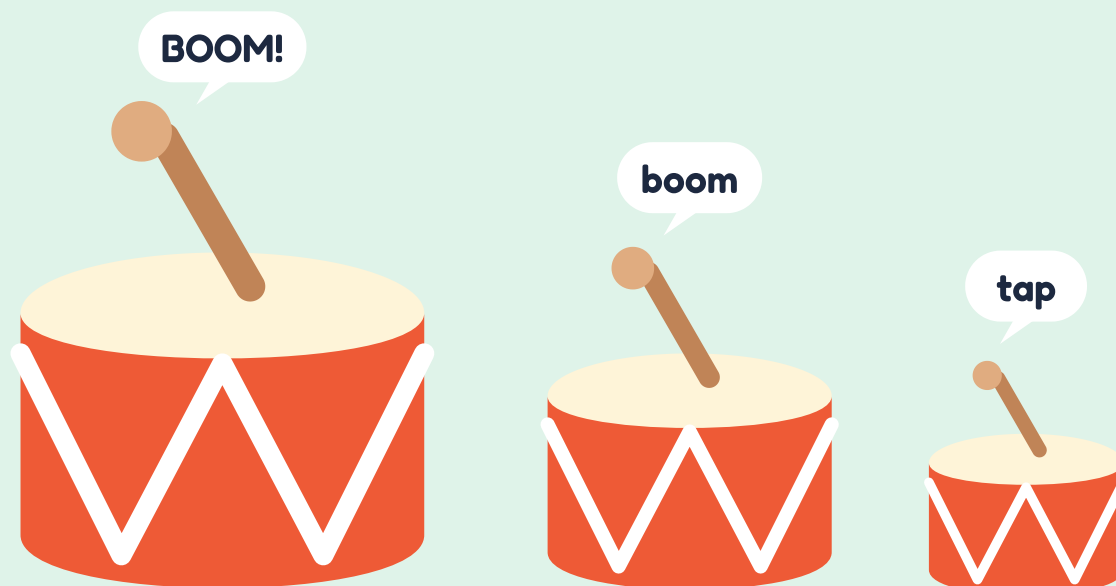
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Drum along!

Tap and sound. Pat each drum on the page with a flat hand while you say its sound. Big drum, big sound.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

"Boom! Boom! Big drum. Tap, tap, little drum."

MAKE IT EASIER

Pat together, hand over hand.

MAKE IT HARDER

Play loud, then quiet. Can your child copy?

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Pat the table like a drum three times.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



Big and little

Say it with your voice. Use a big, deep voice for big things and a tiny squeaky voice for little ones.

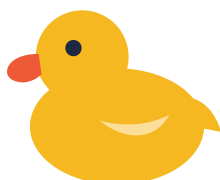


big



little

ball



big



little

duck



big



little

teddy



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"BIG ball! (tiny voice) little ball."

MAKE IT EASIER

Just the balls. Point and use your two voices.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask "Which one is little?" and wait for a point.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Say "big" with arms wide and "little" with a pinch.

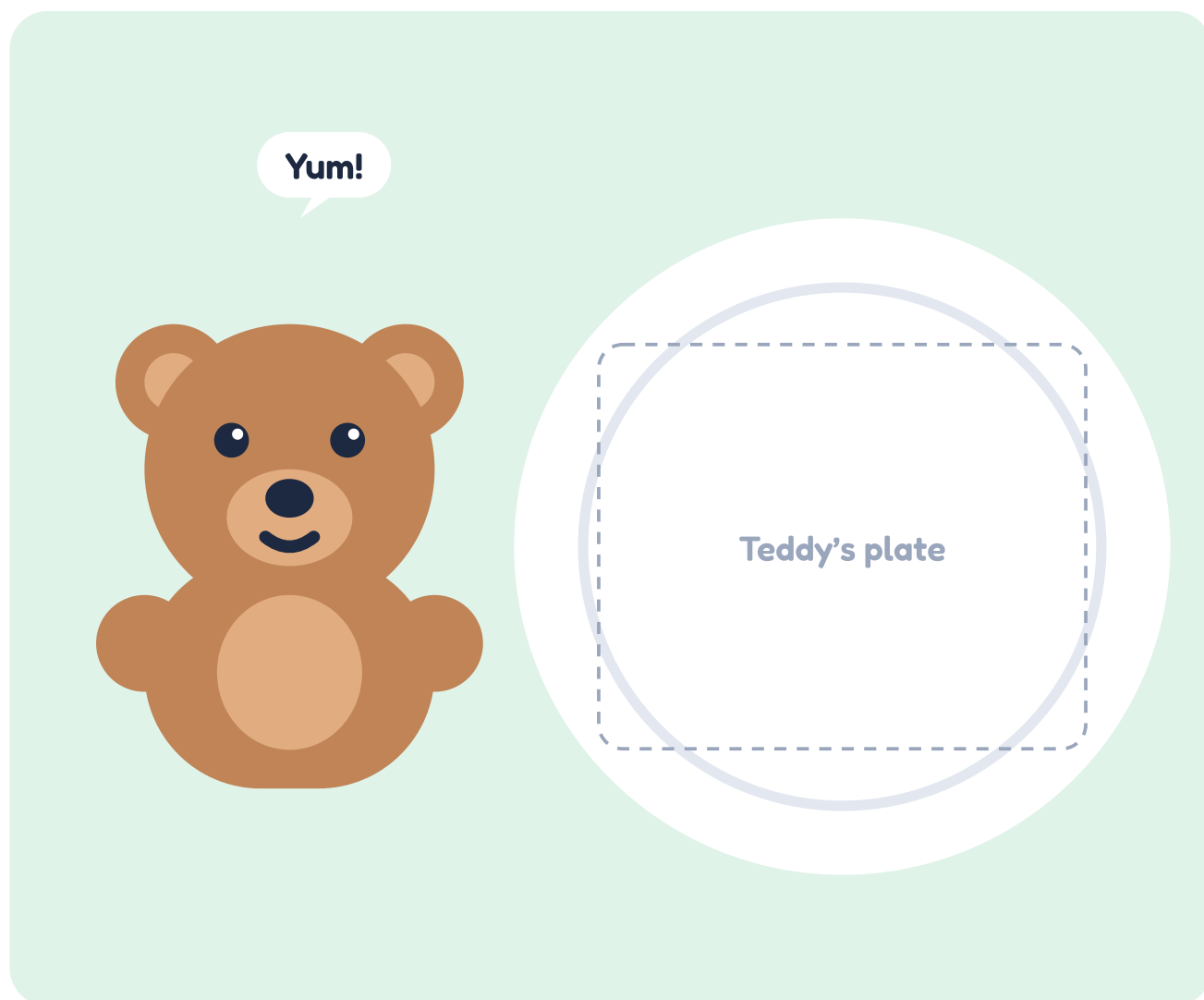
📍 1-2 years · from 18 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



Lunch for Teddy

Feed Teddy. Your child picks a food card and puts it on Teddy's plate. Teddy says "yum!" (That's your job.)



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Banana or toast for Teddy? Toast! Yum, yum!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Offer just two cards.

MAKE IT HARDER

Let your child be the grown-up: "Is Teddy hungry? What next?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

One card on the plate. Teddy says "yum!"

📍 1-2 years · from 18 months ⌚ Prep: 5 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 34: Lunch for Teddy

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



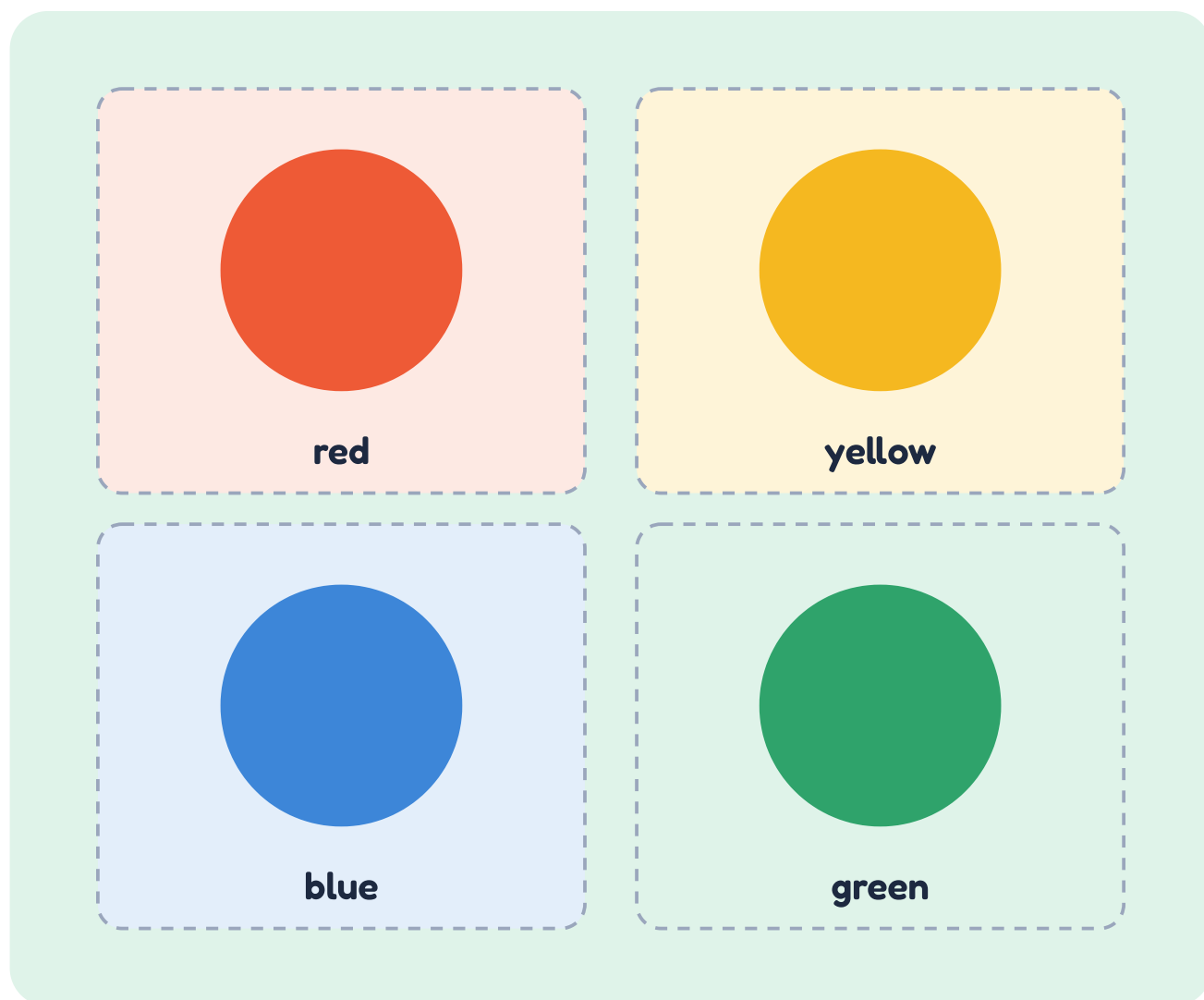
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Red, yellow, blue, green

Match the color. Lay a card on the mat with the same color. Say the color word every time; knowing it comes later.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Apple. Red apple. Red, red, red!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Use red and yellow only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Find something in the room that is the same color.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

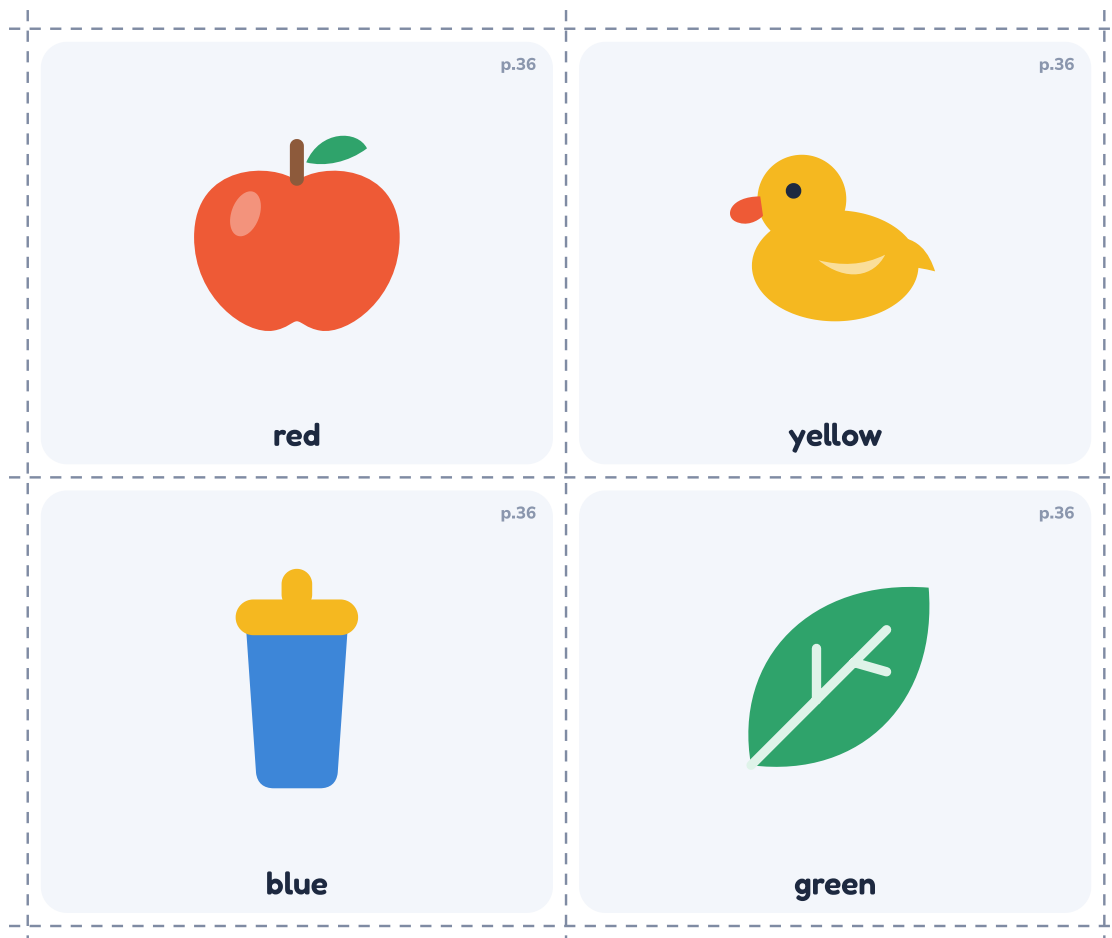
Name one color on the page, then find it on their clothes.

📍 1-2 years · from 20 months ⌚ Prep: 5 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 36: Red, yellow, blue, green

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



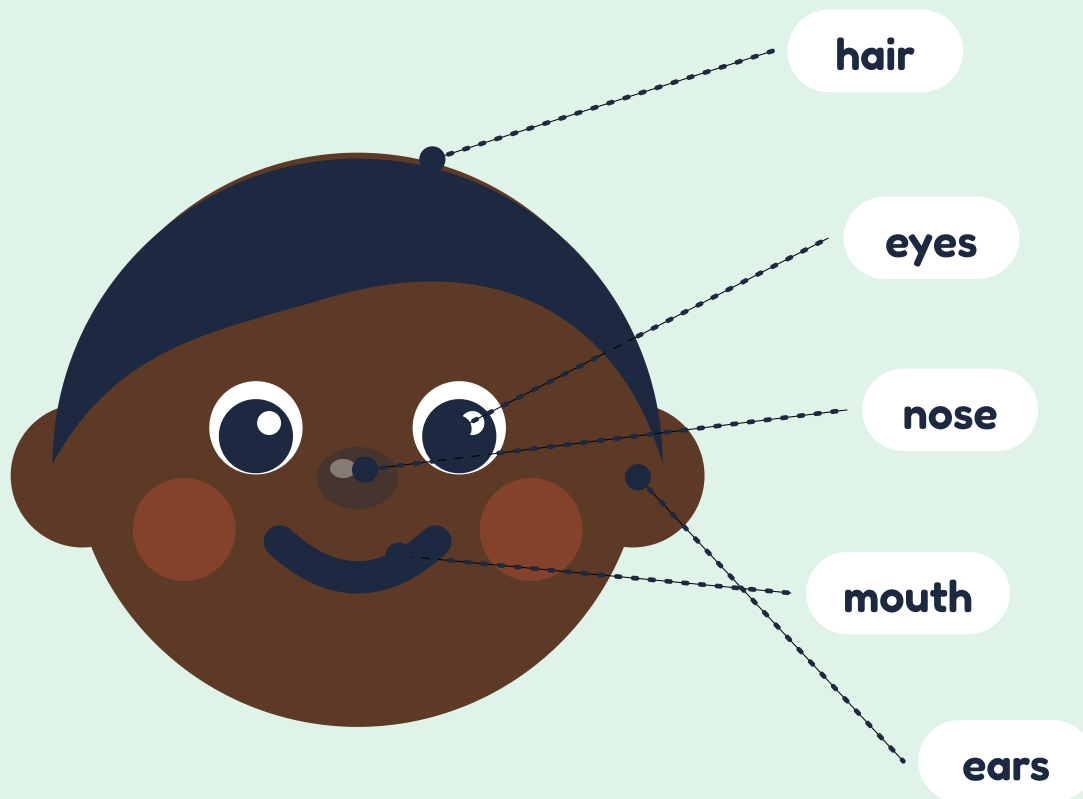
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Where's your nose?

Point here, then there. Point to the nose in the picture, then gently touch your child's nose. Swap turns.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"Nose! Your nose. My nose! Beep!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Only nose and eyes today.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask "Where are your ears?" and wait for them to show you.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Beep each other's noses. Done.

📍 1-2 years · from 15 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



Pick a song

Let your child choose. Hold the page and ask “Which song?” A look or a pat picks it. Sing and do the moves.



Row, Row, Row Your Boat

rock side to side



Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star

open and shut your hands



The Wheels on the Bus

roll your arms round



Old MacDonald Had a Farm

moo! baa! quack!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

“Boat song or star song? (wait) Star! Twinkle, twinkle...”

MAKE IT EASIER

Sing the same song every time.
Repeating is the fun part.

MAKE IT HARDER

Stop before the last word of a line and
let them fill it in.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Hum one song while you rock together.

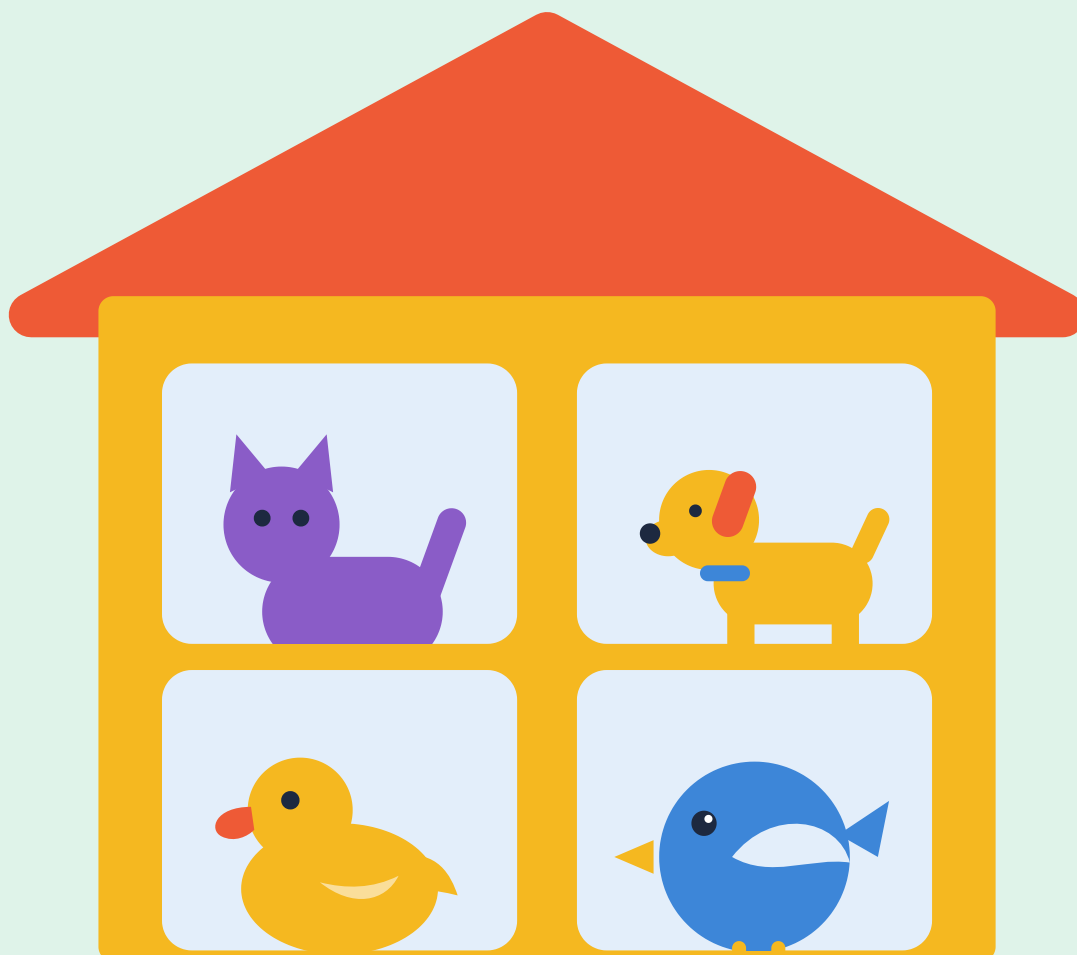
📍 **1-2 years** · from 12 months ⌚ **Prep: 0 min** 💧 **Mess: None** 📁 **Needs: Just this page**

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Rocking games stay gentle: support your child's back and head.



Peekaboo house

Hide and pop. Cover a window with your hand. "Where's cat?" Wait a beat, lift your hand: "Peekaboo!"



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Where's dog? (wait...) Peekaboo, dog!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Cover with your hand only a moment.
Quick hides are easiest.

MAKE IT HARDER

Let your child do the hiding and you do
the guessing.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

One window, one peekaboo. Big smile.
Done.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

First words: "book"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Press palms together, then open.

book



SIGN IT Press palms together, then open



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"Book! Open the book... wow!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Let them pat the page while you say "book."

MAKE IT HARDER

Let them choose a real book next and name what they point at.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Clap hands shut and open like a book.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.



First words: "more"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Tap your fingertips together.

more



SIGN IT Tap your fingertips together



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"More? (wait) More! Here's more."

MAKE IT EASIER

Tap your fingertips together as you say "more."

MAKE IT HARDER

Pause a game and wait for a sign, sound or look before you go on.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Tickle once, stop, ask "more?" Repeat.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: “uh-oh”

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Hands on cheeks: uh-oh!

uh-oh



ACT IT Hands on cheeks: uh-oh!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

“Uh-oh! It fell down. Uh-oh!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Make a big surprised face. That's the whole game.

MAKE IT HARDER

Drop a soft toy on purpose and wait for them to say it.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Say “uh-oh!” with hands on cheeks. Giggle.

📍 **1-2 years** · from 12 months ⌚ **Prep: 0 min** 💧 **Mess: None** 📁 **Needs: Just this page**

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.



First words: "bye-bye"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Blow a kiss: mwah!

bye-bye



ACT IT Blow a kiss: mwah!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

"Bye-bye, dog! Bye-bye, duck! Bye-bye, book!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Wave for them. Watching counts.

MAKE IT HARDER

Say bye-bye to everything in the room before you leave.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Blow a kiss to the page: "mwah!"

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📦 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: “night-night”

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Whisper: shhh... zzz.

night-night



SAY IT Whisper: shhh... zzz



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat

“Night-night, moon. Night-night, duck. Shhh...”

MAKE IT EASIER

Whisper it, slowly. Quiet voices are lovely to copy.

MAKE IT HARDER

Tuck in three toys and say night-night to each.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Whisper “night-night” and rest your heads together.

📍 1-2 years · from 12 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

2–3 years

Busy explorers

Match, sort and pretend. Colors, shapes, pairs and first little stories.



What this age often loves

- Matching and sorting
- Colors, shapes and pairs
- Pretend play: cooking, dressing up, driving
- “In, on, under” and other little words
- Doing it “by myself”

In this section

23 activities · 14 no-cut pages · starting from 24 months.

Start with whatever your child is into today. Skip anything that isn't fun yet, and come back later.

Every child grows at their own pace. Ages are starting points, not deadlines. Questions about your child's development? Your pediatrician is the best person to ask.

First words: "go"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Ready, set... go!

go



SAY IT Ready, set... go!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Ready, set... (wait) GO!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Say the whole thing and zoom a toy car.

MAKE IT HARDER

Stop after "Ready, set..." and let your child say "go!"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Say "ready, set, go!" and clap on go.

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "stop"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Hold up a flat hand.

stop



ACT IT Hold up a flat hand



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Go, go, go... STOP!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Hold up a flat hand as you say it.

MAKE IT HARDER

Swap turns: your child says "stop!" and you freeze.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Walk fingers across the page, then freeze.

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: “down”

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Let your voice slide: dooown!

down



SAY IT Let your voice slide: dooown!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

“Down, down, dooown the slide!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Slide a finger down the picture as you say it.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask: “What else goes down?” A spoon?
A block?

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Crouch down low together. “Dooown!”

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "in"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. In it goes... plop!

in



SAY IT In it goes... plop!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat

"In it goes... plop! In! In! In!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Drop a big block into a bowl for them to watch.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try "in" and "out" with the same bowl.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Put one sock in a shoe. "In!"

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

Color sort

Sort by color. Pick up a card, name it, and put it on the mat with the same color. Mistakes are fine; just name what you see.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Frog. Green frog. Green frog goes on green!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Start with two colors and six cards.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask "What else is red?" and hunt the room.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

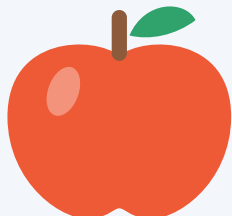
Sort just three cards. Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 51: Color sort

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



p.51

apple



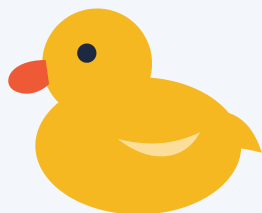
p.51

car



p.51

heart



p.51

duck



p.51

banana



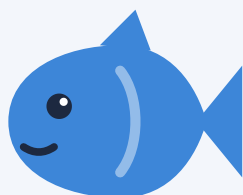
p.51

star



p.51

cup



p.51

fish



p.51

shoe



p.51

leaf



p.51

frog



p.51

pear



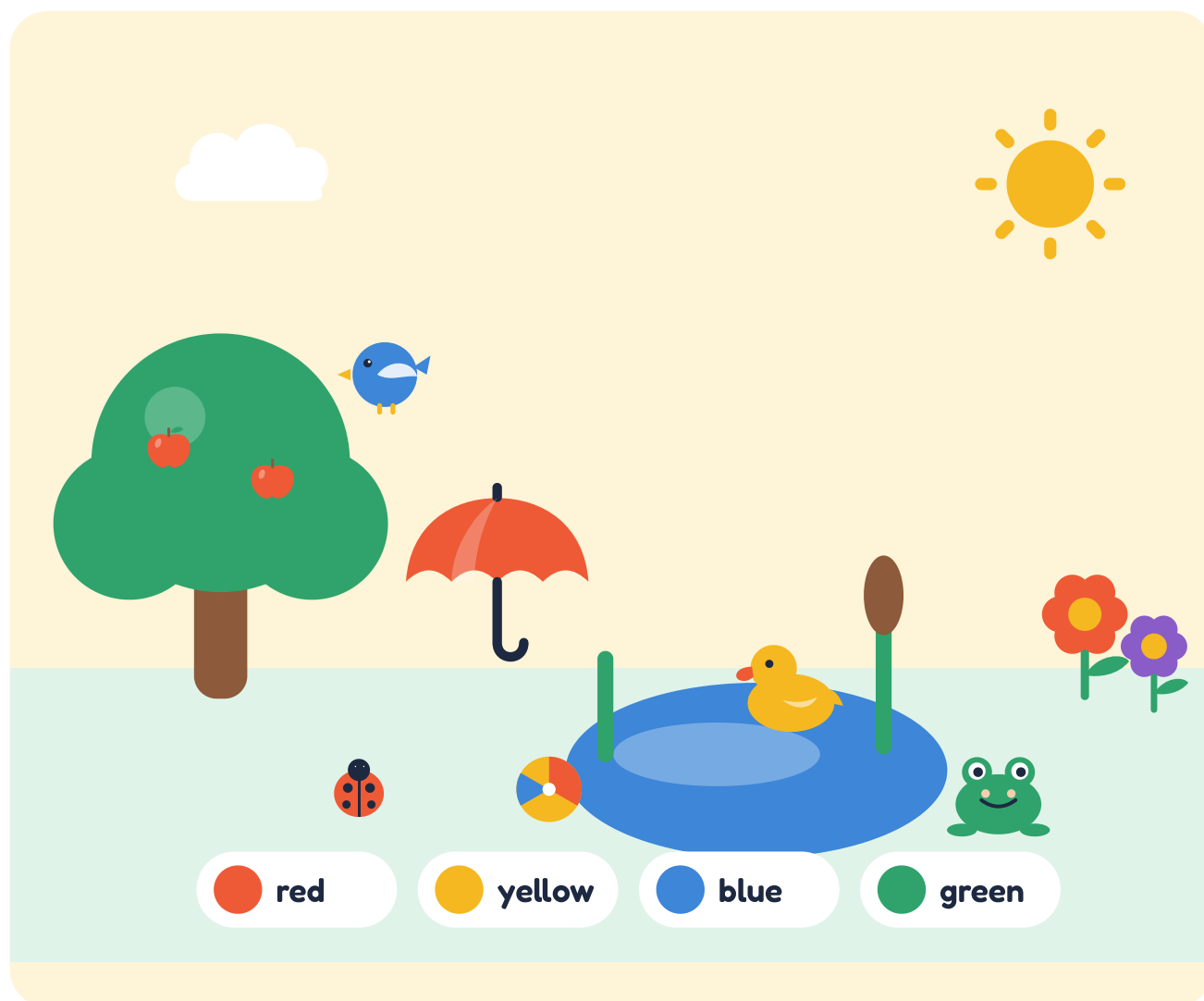
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Color hunt in the park

Hunt for a color. Touch a color dot at the bottom, then find that color in the park. Every find gets a name.



 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY** · Say what you see

"Yellow! Yellow duck. Yellow sun. Wow, lots of yellow!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Hunt one color only. Yellow is easy to spot.

MAKE IT HARDER

Find two things of the same color and say both.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Point to anything red. Name it. Done.

 **2-3 years** · from 24 months  **Prep: 0 min**  **Mess: None**  **Needs: Just this page**

 **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Shape match

Find the shape's spot. Pick up a shape card, trace its edge with a finger, then lay it on the pale shape that matches.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Circle. Round, round circle. It goes on the circle!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Circle, square and triangle only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Find a circle or square in the room: a plate, a window.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

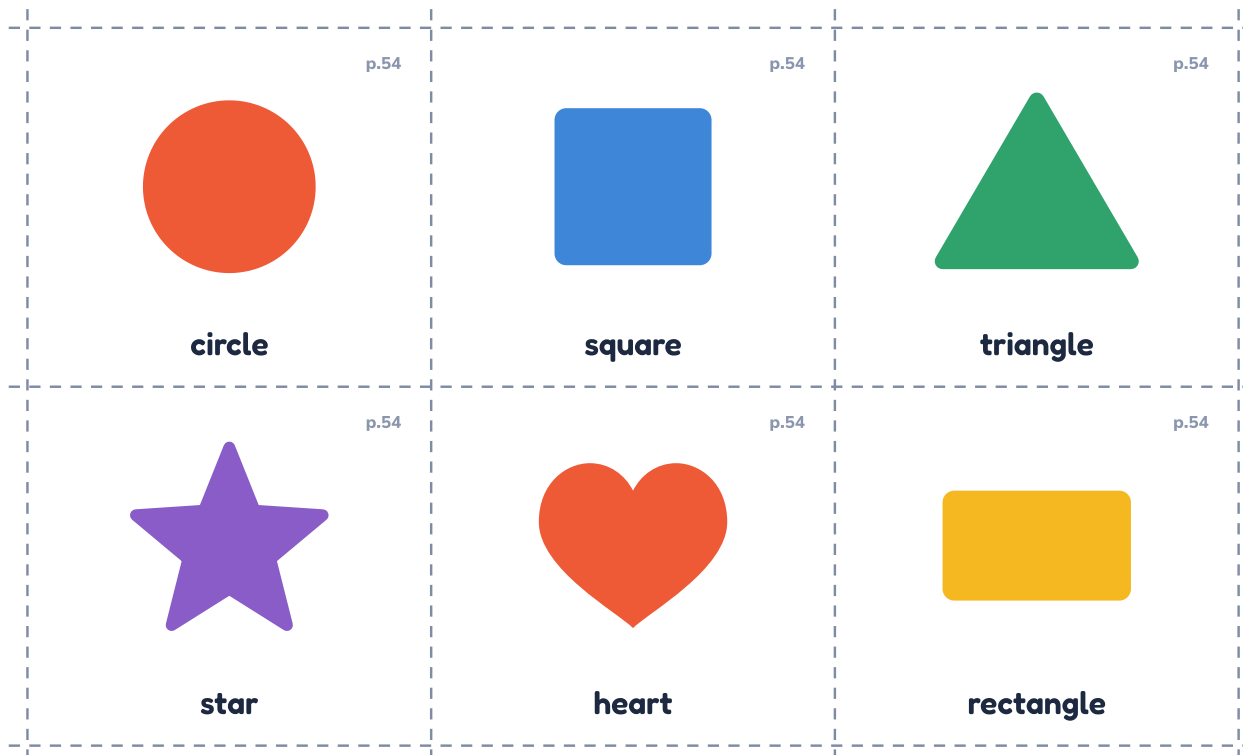
Trace one shape with a finger. Say its name.

📍 2-3 years · from 26 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 54: Shape match

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



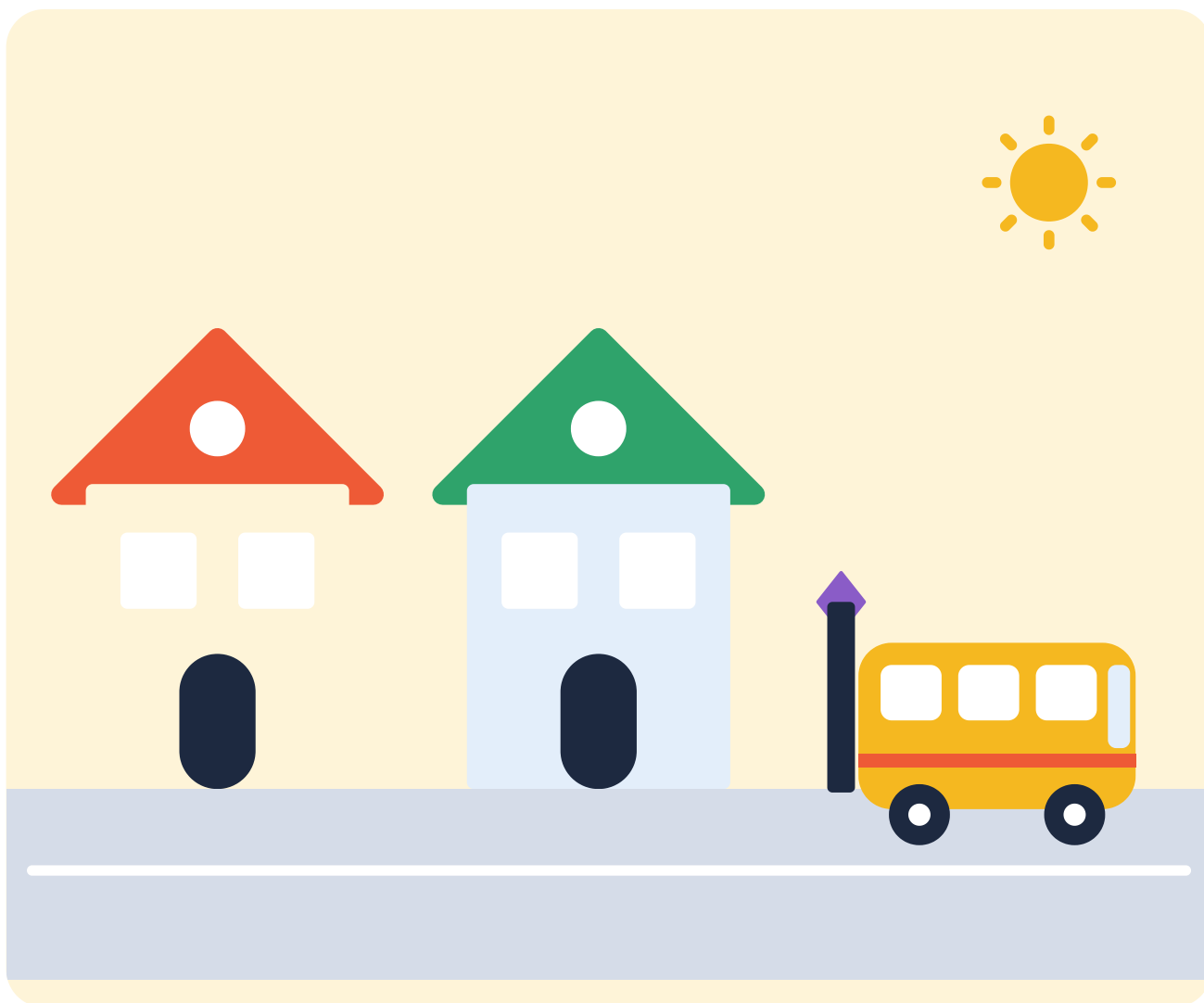
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Shapes everywhere

Spy the shapes. Circles, squares and triangles are hiding in this street. Point and name each one you find.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"The wheel is a circle! The roof is a triangle!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Hunt circles only (wheels, sun, windows).

MAKE IT HARDER

Count the circles together.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Find one triangle. Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 28 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Shadow match

Whose shadow? Hold up a card, look at the dark shapes together, and find the shadow that matches.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Is this the duck's shadow or the cup's? (wait) The duck's!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Put out three cards and three shadows only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Cover a shadow with your hand and ask which one is missing.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

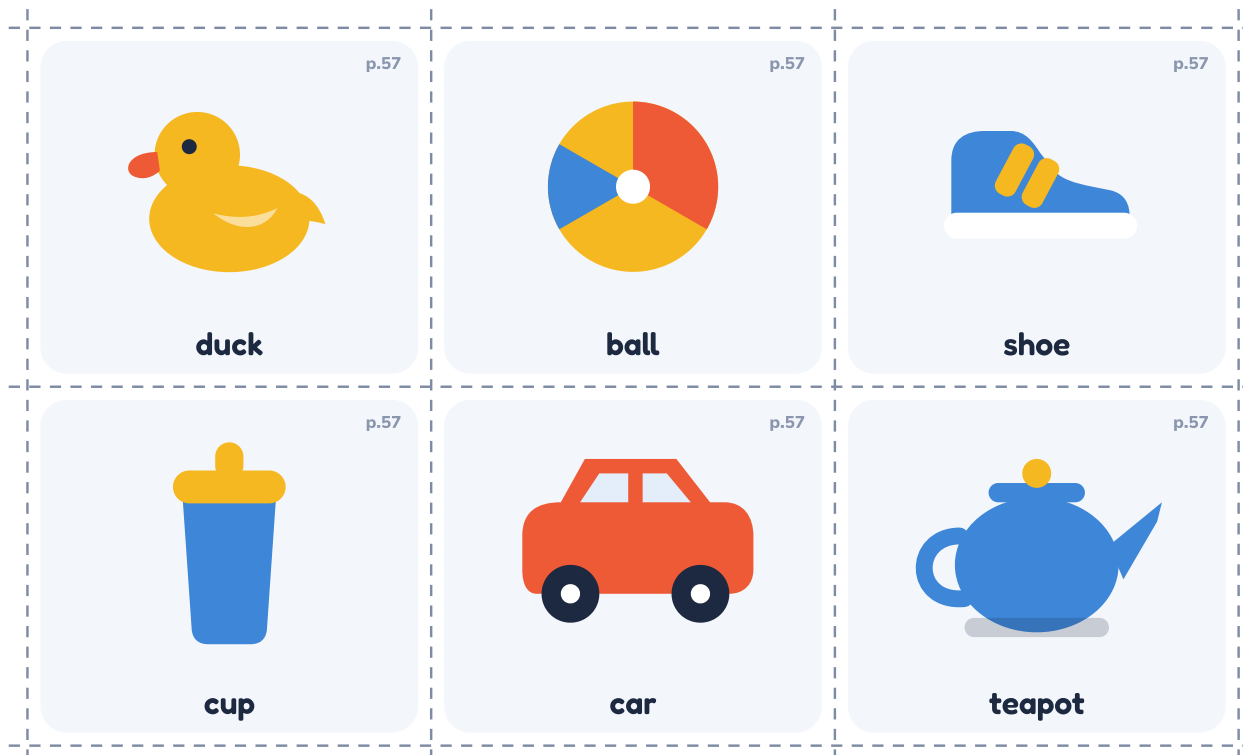
Match one card. High-five.

📍 2-3 years · from 28 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 57: Shadow match

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.

Big or small?

Sort by size. Look at the picture on each card. Is it big or small? Put it on the matching side.



BIG

Big things go here



small

Small things go here



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Big duck! Small duck. Small duck goes here."

MAKE IT EASIER

Balls only: one big, one small.

MAKE IT HARDER

Line them up from small to big.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

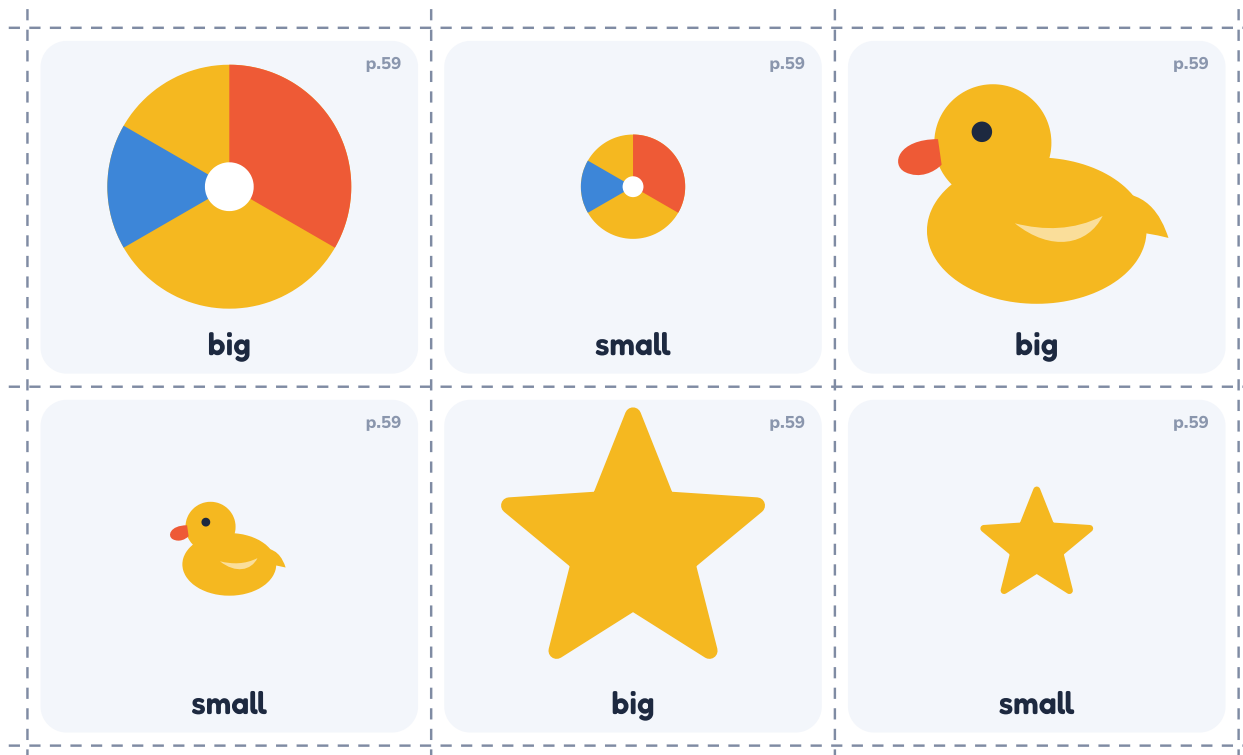
Sort two cards. Done.

📍 **2-3 years** · from 26 months ⌚ **Prep: 10 min** 💧 **Mess: None** 🛠 **Needs: Scissors, cardstock**

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 59: Big or small?

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Dress for the weather

What will they wear? Pick a card. Is it for the sunny day or the rainy, chilly day? Dress the right friend.



Sunny day



Rainy,
chilly day



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Sun hat or boots for the sunny day? (wait) Sun hat!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Two cards at a time: one sunny, one rainy.

MAKE IT HARDER

Look outside. What should we wear today?

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Look out the window and name the weather.

📍 2-3 years · from 28 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 61: Dress for the weather

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

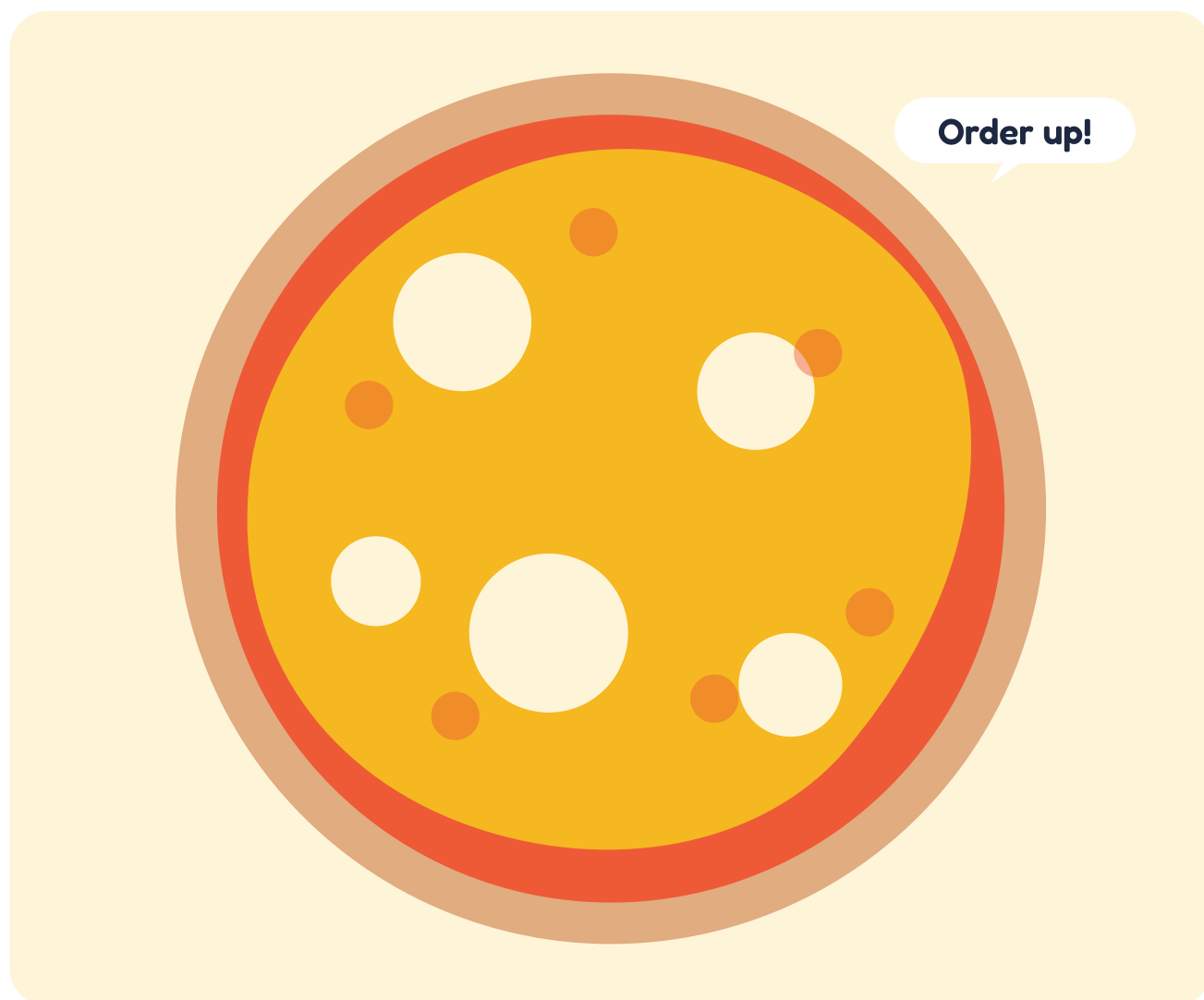


Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.

Pizza shop

Make a pizza together. Your child is the cook. Ask for toppings and let them lay the cards on the pizza.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Mushrooms or peppers? (wait) Peppers! One more?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Two kinds of topping only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Order a number: "Three tomatoes, please!"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

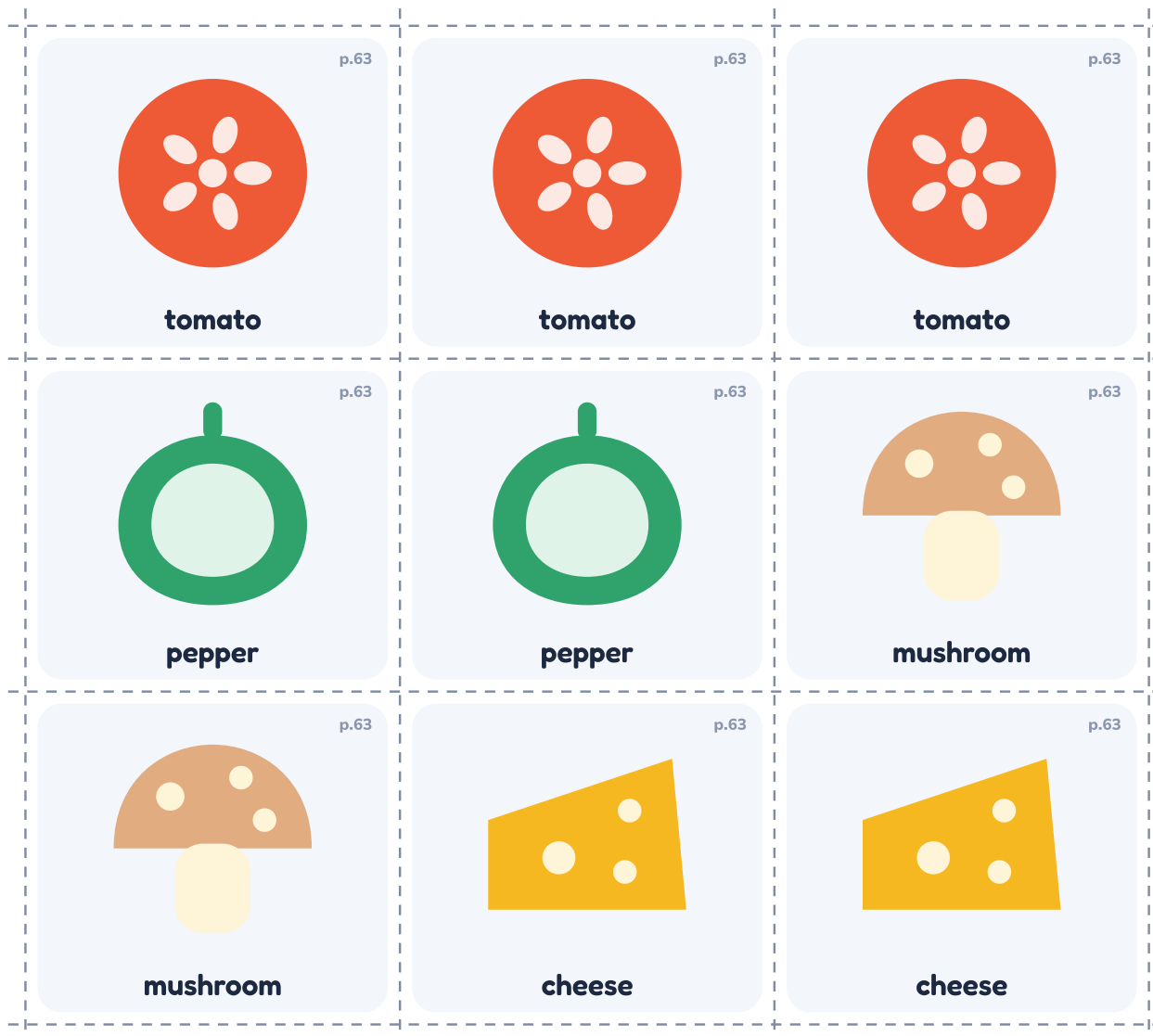
Order one topping. Pretend to munch. Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 28 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 63: Pizza shop

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Same feeling

Match faces that feel the same. Look at a card face. Make that face together, then find the friend who feels the same.



silly



sad



surprised



sleepy



happy



mad



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"She looks sleepy. Yawn! Who else is sleepy?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Happy and sad only. Read the word on the card as you point: faces can be hard to read.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask "What made him sad, do you think?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Make a silly face at each other. Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 65: Same feeling

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



In, on, under

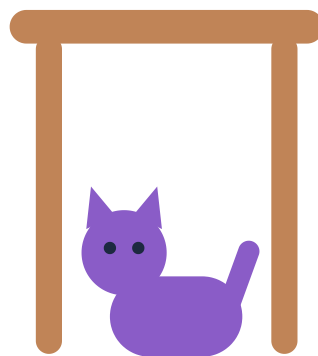
Where is Cat? Point to each picture and say where Cat is. Then play it with a real toy and a box.



in



on



under



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Cat is IN the box! Now Cat is ON the box!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Just "in." Drop a toy in a box: "in!"

MAKE IT HARDER

Hide a toy and give clues: "It's under something soft."

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Put a sock in a shoe: "in!" Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



First words: "open"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Close your hands, then pop them open.

open



ACT IT Close your hands, then pop them open



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Open? (wait) Open the box!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Open and close your hands like a box.

MAKE IT HARDER

Hold a lidded box shut and wait for them to ask.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Open and shut your hands three times.

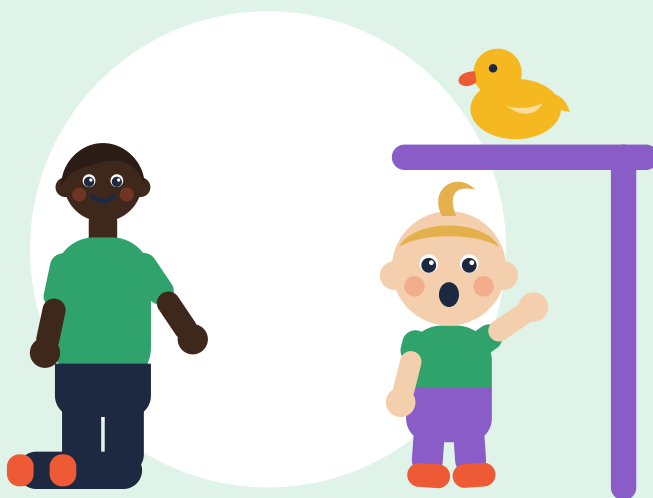
📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "help"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Thumbs-up on open palm, lift up.

help



SIGN IT Thumbs-up on open palm, lift up



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Help, please? I can help! Up it goes."

MAKE IT EASIER

Model it: "Help, please!" and do it together.

MAKE IT HARDER

Put a toy just out of reach and wait for a point, sign or word.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

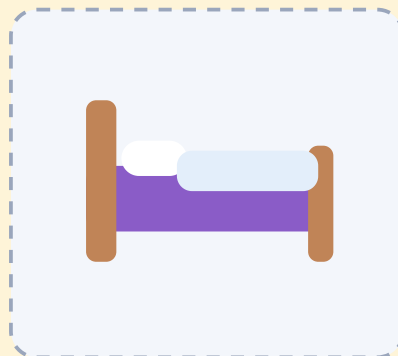
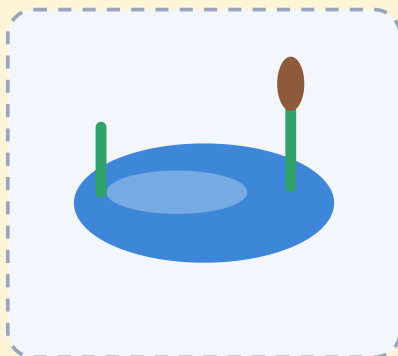
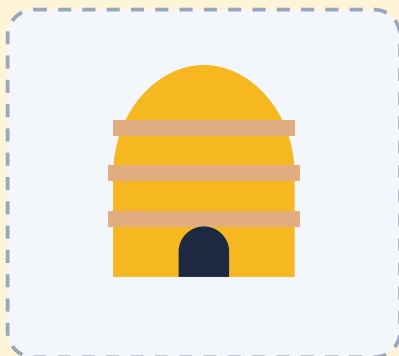
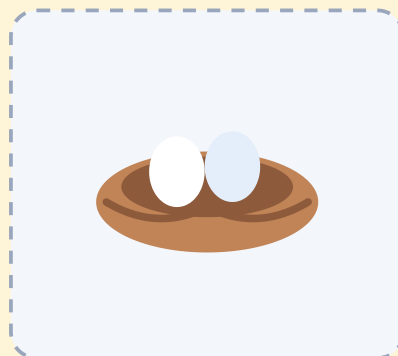
Ask your child to help you turn the page.

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

Who lives here?

Take everyone home. Pick an animal card and ask “Where does the bird live?” Lay it on its home.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

“The bird lives in a... (wait) nest! Tweet!”

MAKE IT EASIER

Dog and fish first; they're easy.

MAKE IT HARDER

Ask “Where do you live? Where do I sleep?”

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

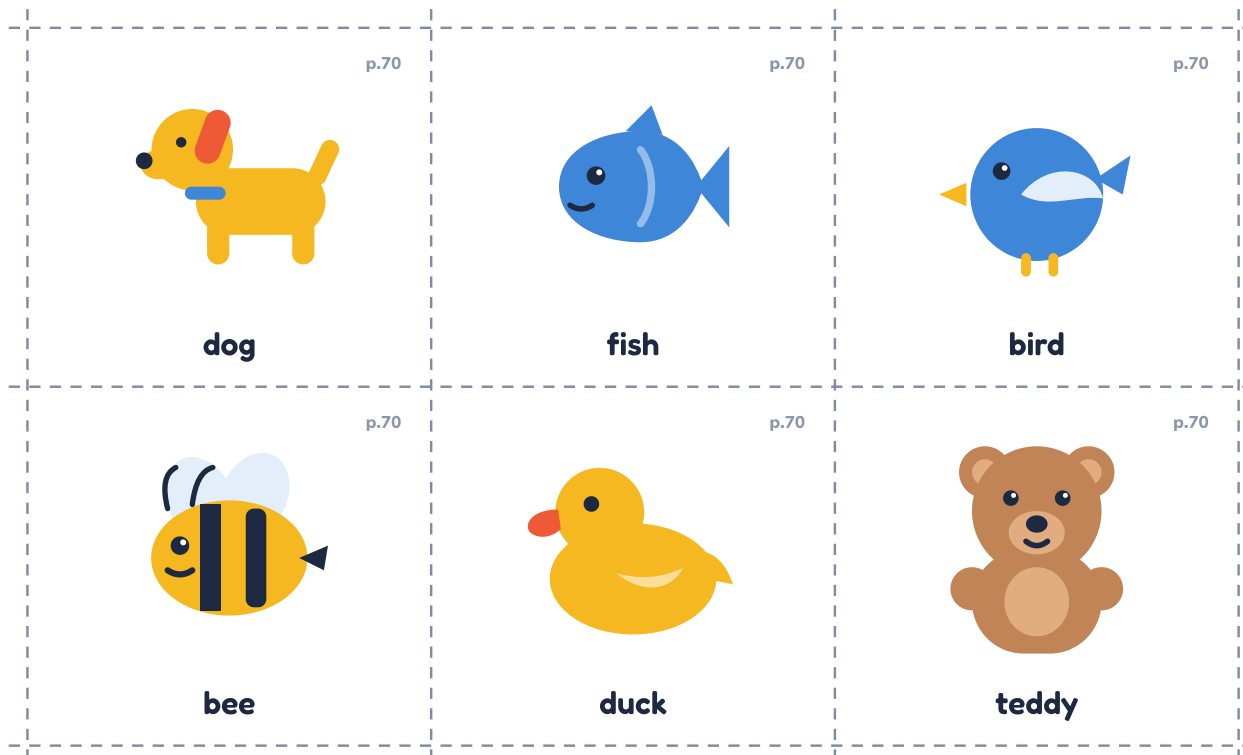
Take one animal home. Say night-night.

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 70: Who lives here?

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Opposites

Two sides, two words. Point to one side and say its word. Then point to the other side and say the opposite.



day



night



hot



cold



up



down



open



shut



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Day. Sunny day! Night. Dark night. Shhh."

MAKE IT EASIER

Day and night only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Act them out: stretch up high, crouch down low.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Open and shut your hands: "open... shut!"

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

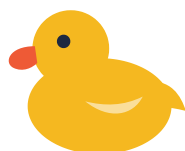
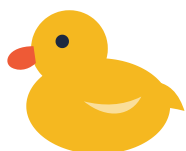
✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

One, two, three

Touch and count. Touch each picture as you count out loud, one touch for each number.



one sun



two ducks



three stars

 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat

"One duck! One, two ducks! One, two, three stars!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Count the one sun, then clap once.

MAKE IT HARDER

Count claps, hops or steps up to three.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Count three fingers on your hand. Done.

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🗑️ Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Find the pair

Match the socks. Look closely: stripes, dots, stars. Find the sock that makes a pair and lay it on its partner.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"This sock has dots. Blue dots! Where's its friend?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Put out three pairs only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Pair real socks from the laundry basket after.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Find one real pair of socks together.

📍 2-3 years · from 30 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. No velcro dots for under-3s: lay pieces on top.

Pieces for page 74: Find the pair

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



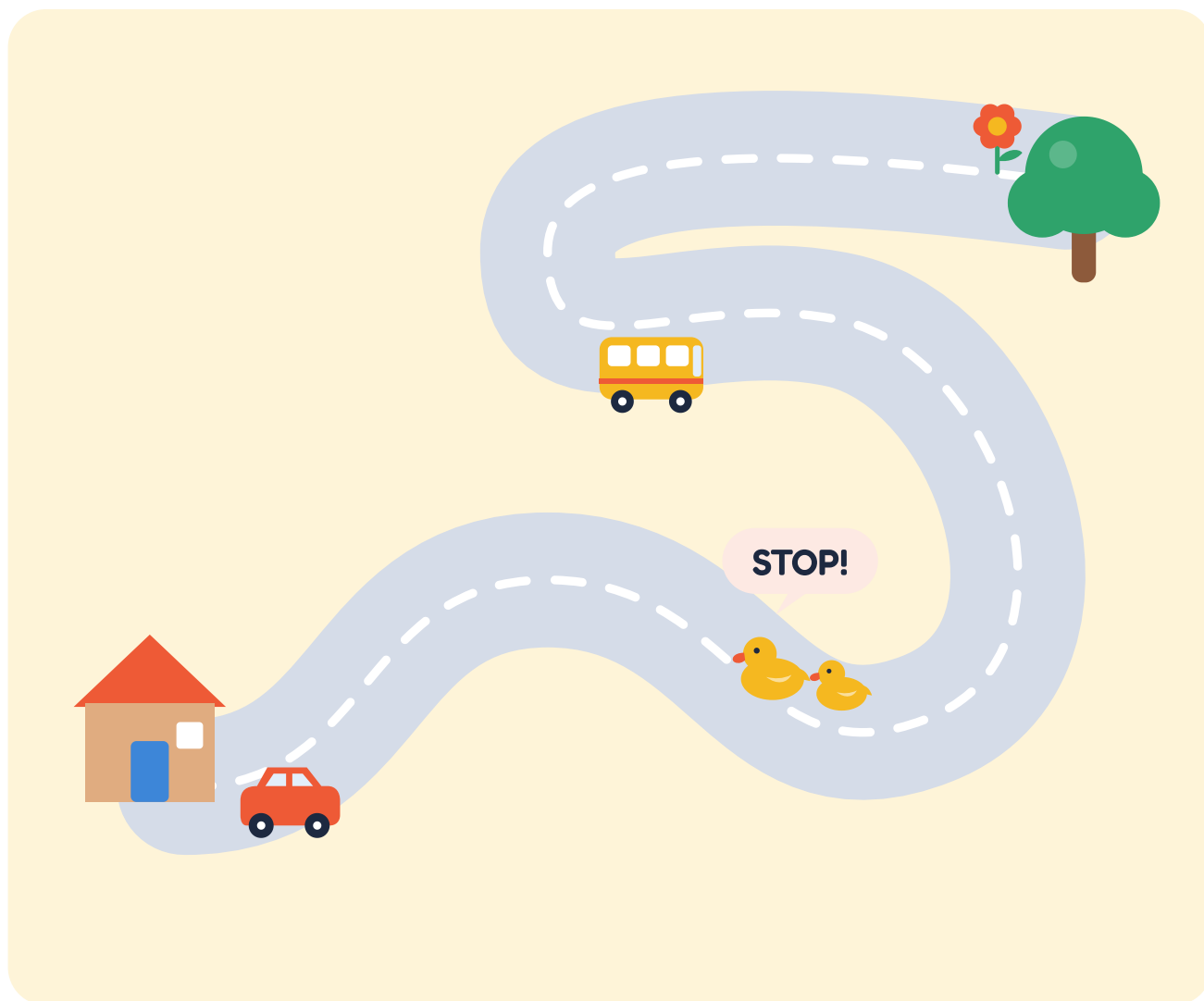
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. **No velcro dots for under-3s:** lay pieces on top. Throw away torn or peeling pieces.



Beep beep! Drive to the park

Drive with a finger. Start at the house and drive along the road to the park. Stop for the ducks!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Go, go, go... ducks! (wait) STOP! Quack, quack."

MAKE IT EASIER

Drive together, your hand over theirs.

MAKE IT HARDER

Add a stop at every picture and say what you see.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Drive once, beep once. Done.

📍 2–3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (or a big toy car)



Play together, with a grown-up right there. Toy cars for under-3s must be bigger than a toilet-paper tube, with no small wheels that come off.

First words: "clap"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Clap, clap, clap!

clap



ACT IT Clap, clap, clap!



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

"Clap, clap, clap! Your turn!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Clap their hands gently in yours.

MAKE IT HARDER

Clap a pattern: slow, slow, fast-fast.
Can they copy?

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Clap three times, then high-five.

📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

First words: "all done"

Point, say, do. Point to the picture and say the word. Then do it together. Open hands up, twist back and forth.

all done



SIGN IT Open hands up, twist back and forth



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"More, or all done?" (hold up a hand for each)

MAKE IT EASIER

Shake open hands and say it at the end of snack.

MAKE IT HARDER

Let them decide when a game is all done, and say it together.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Shake hands side to side: "all done!"

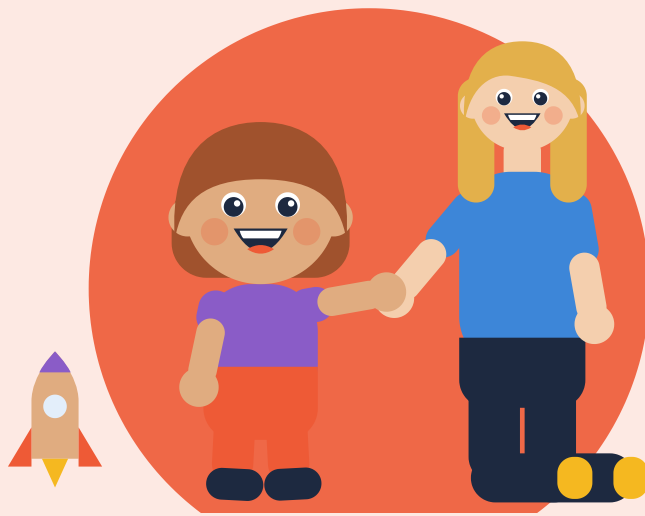
📍 2-3 years · from 24 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Pages are for pointing and patting, not mouthing: hold the page for your child.

3–5 years

Big thinkers

Mazes, counting, patterns, sequencing and bigger pretend play.



What this age often loves

- Mazes and roads for a finger or crayon
- Counting, patterns and first-next-last stories
- Bigger pretend play: shop, café, post office
- Rhymes and “which one is different?”
- Being the one who explains

In this section

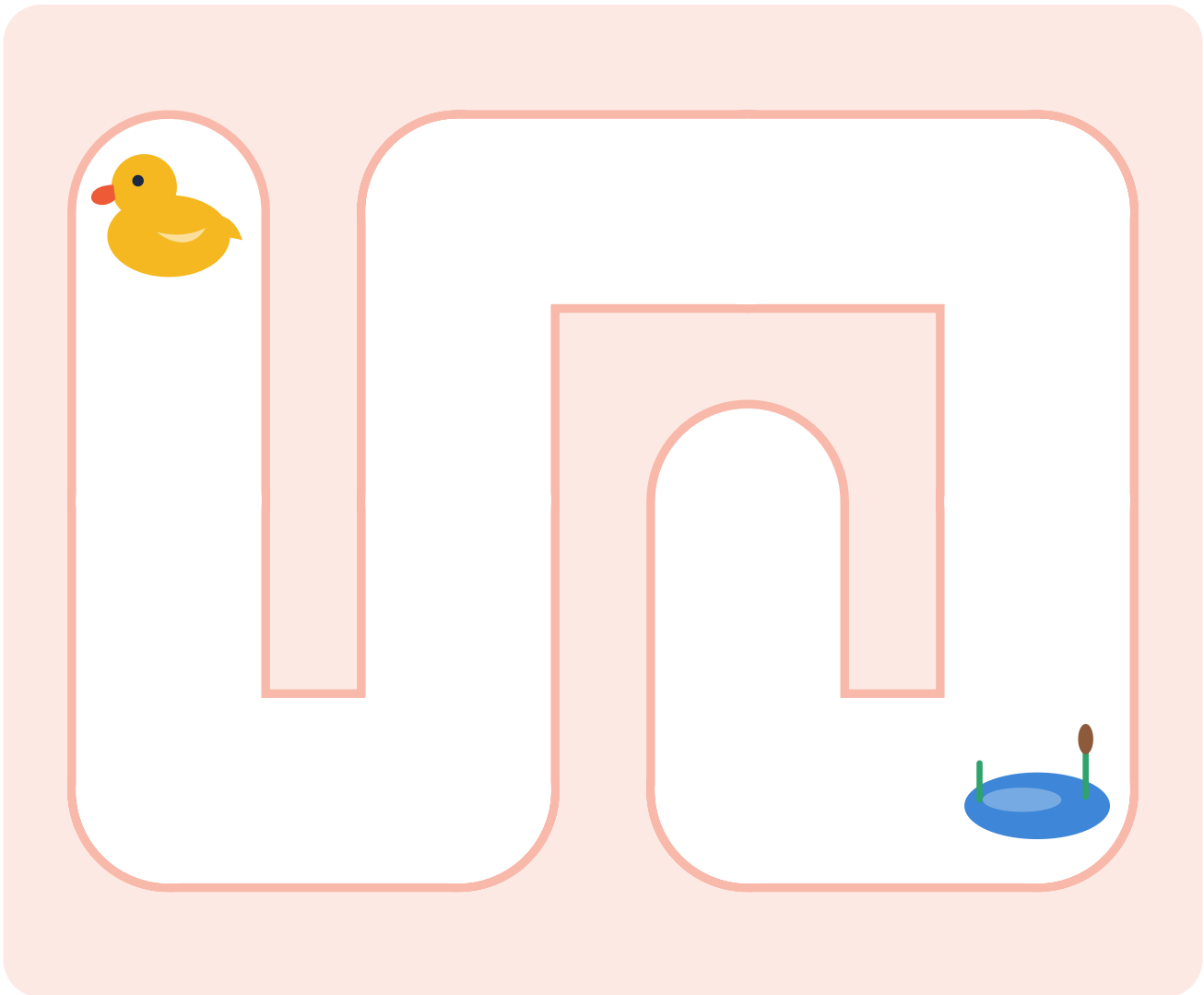
29 activities · 17 no-cut pages · starting from 3 years.

Start with whatever your child is into today. Skip anything that isn't fun yet, and come back later.

Every child grows at their own pace. Ages are starting points, not deadlines. Questions about your child's development? Your pediatrician is the best person to ask.

Help Duck get to the pond

Finger first. Trace the white path from Duck to the pond. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Up, up... turn! Almost there. Splash!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Trace it together, your hand over theirs.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

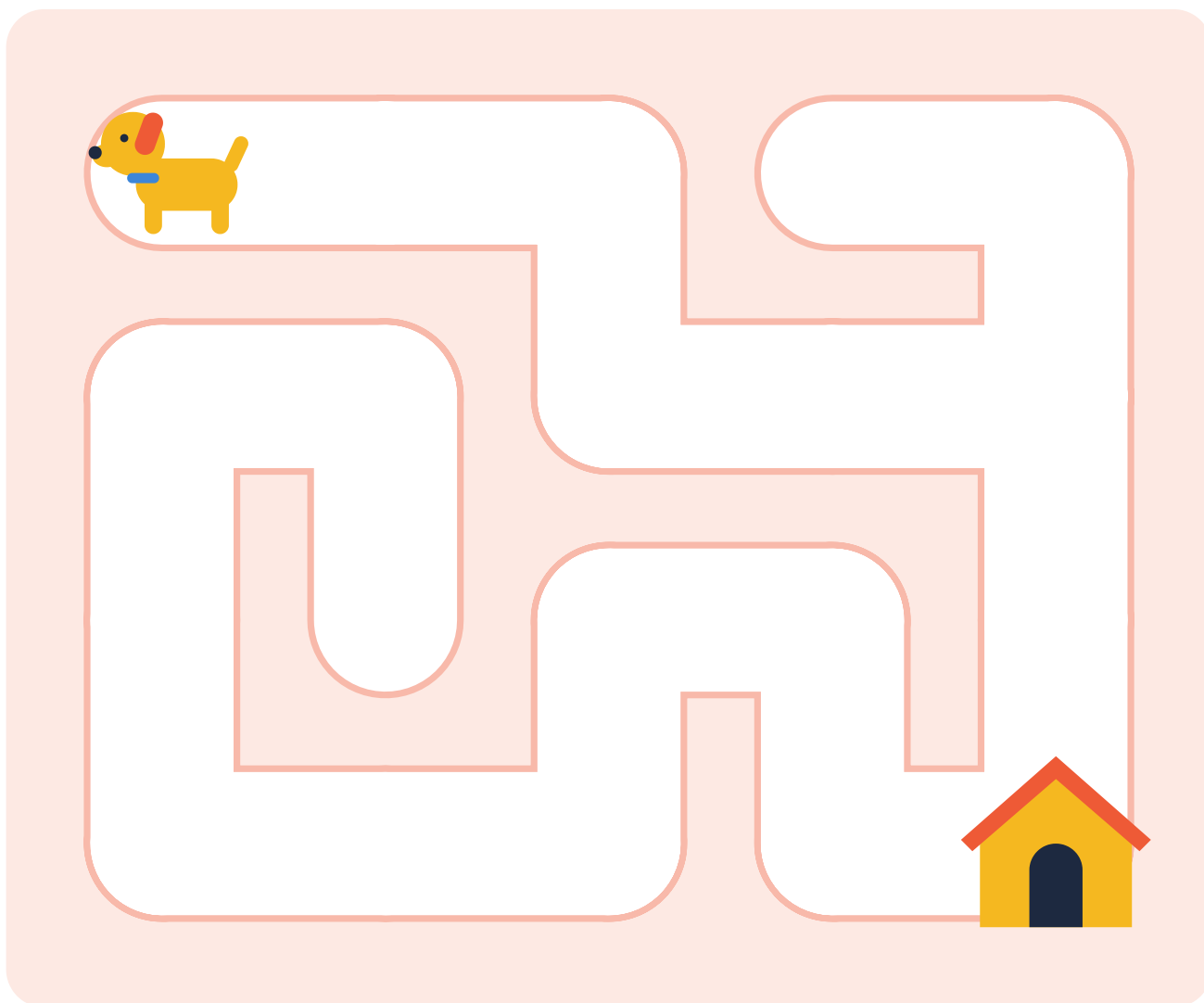
Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3–5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

 **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Help Dog get home

Finger first. Trace the white path from Dog to home. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Which way now? (wait) That way! Woof!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Trace it together, your hand over theirs.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

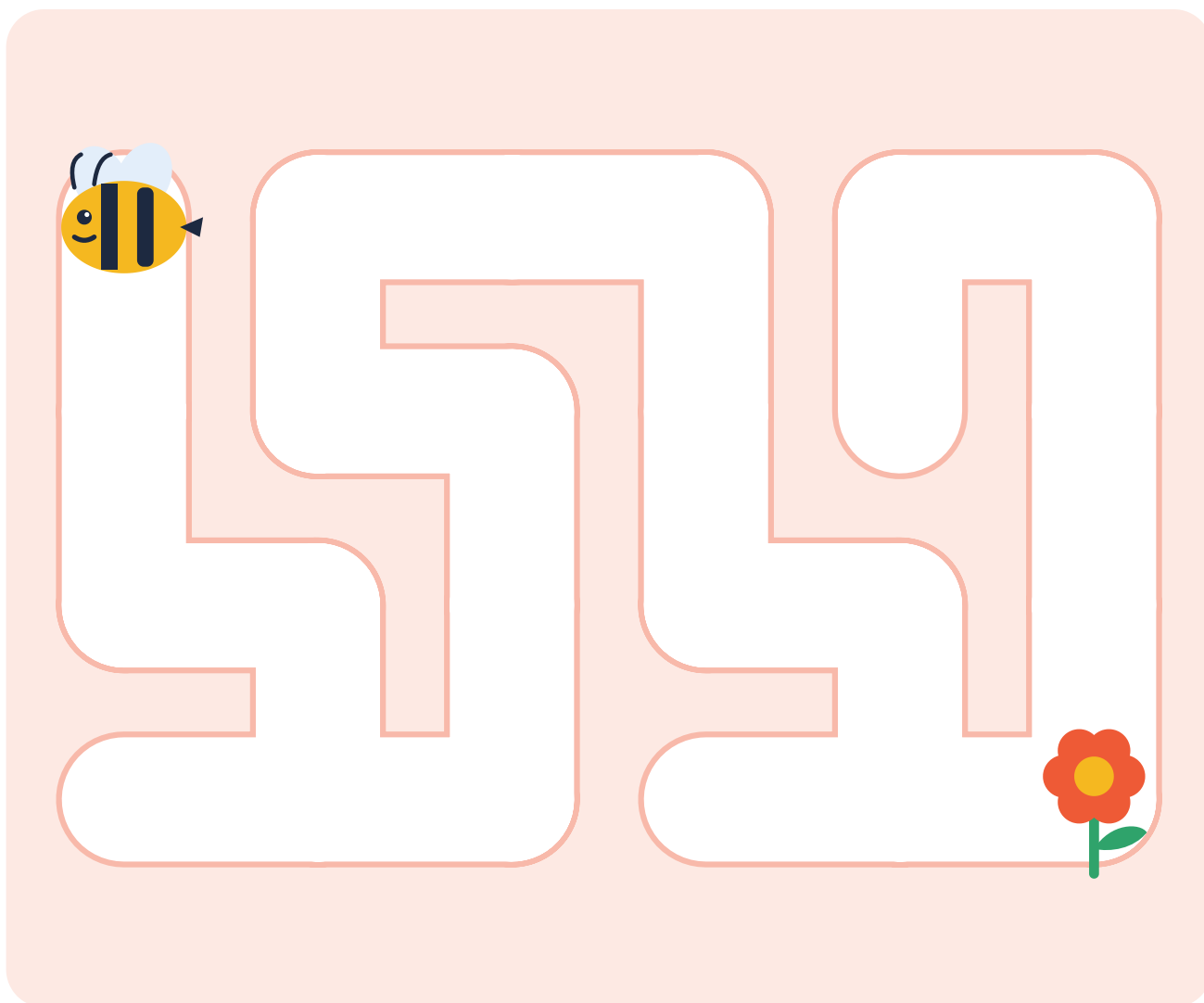
Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Help Bee find the flower

Finger first. Trace the white path from Bee to the flower. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Buzz, buzz... oops, dead end! Back we go."

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

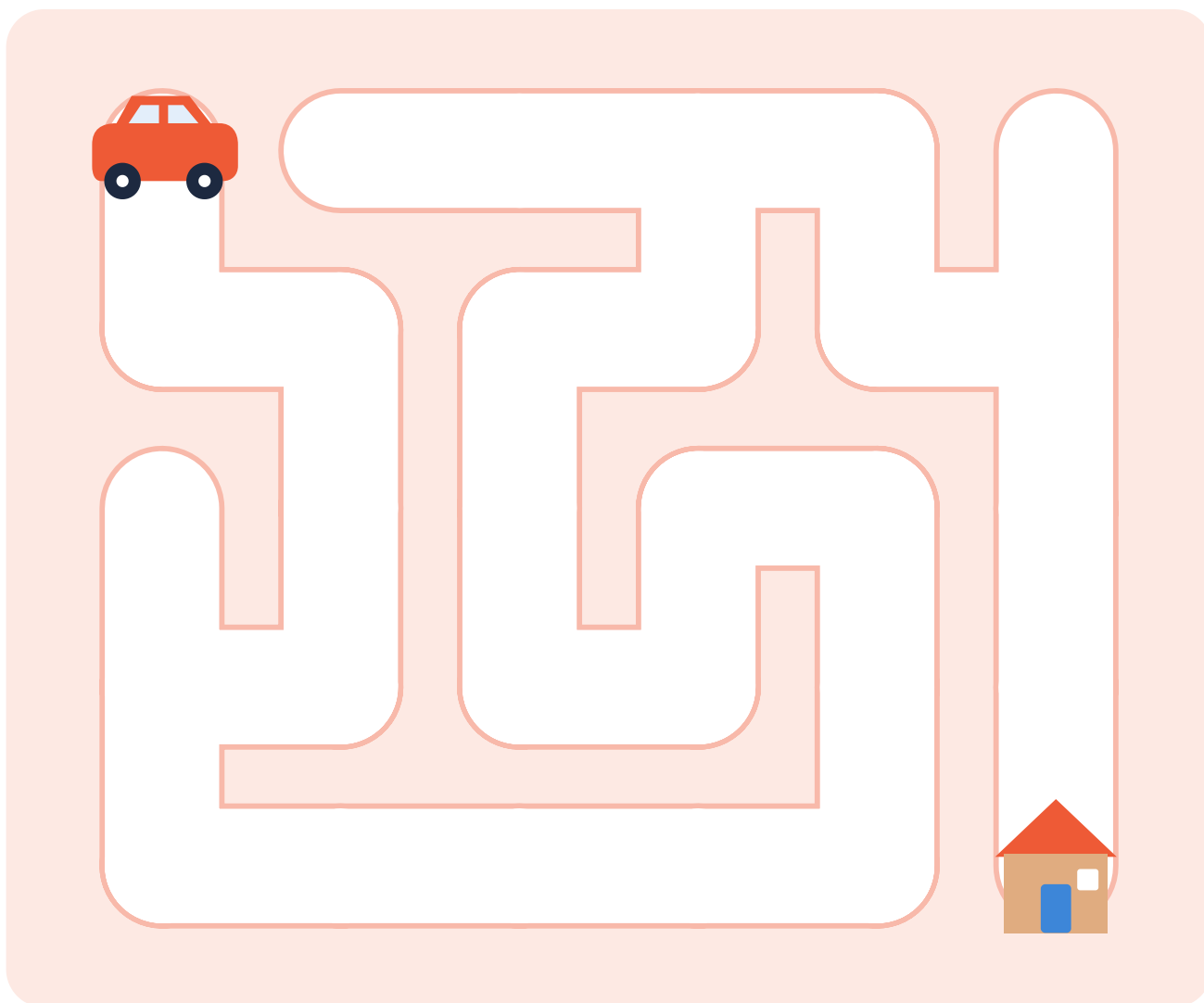
Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 40 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

 Play together, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Drive the car home

Finger first. Trace the white path from the car to home. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Left or right? You choose. Beep beep!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Trace it once with a finger. Done.

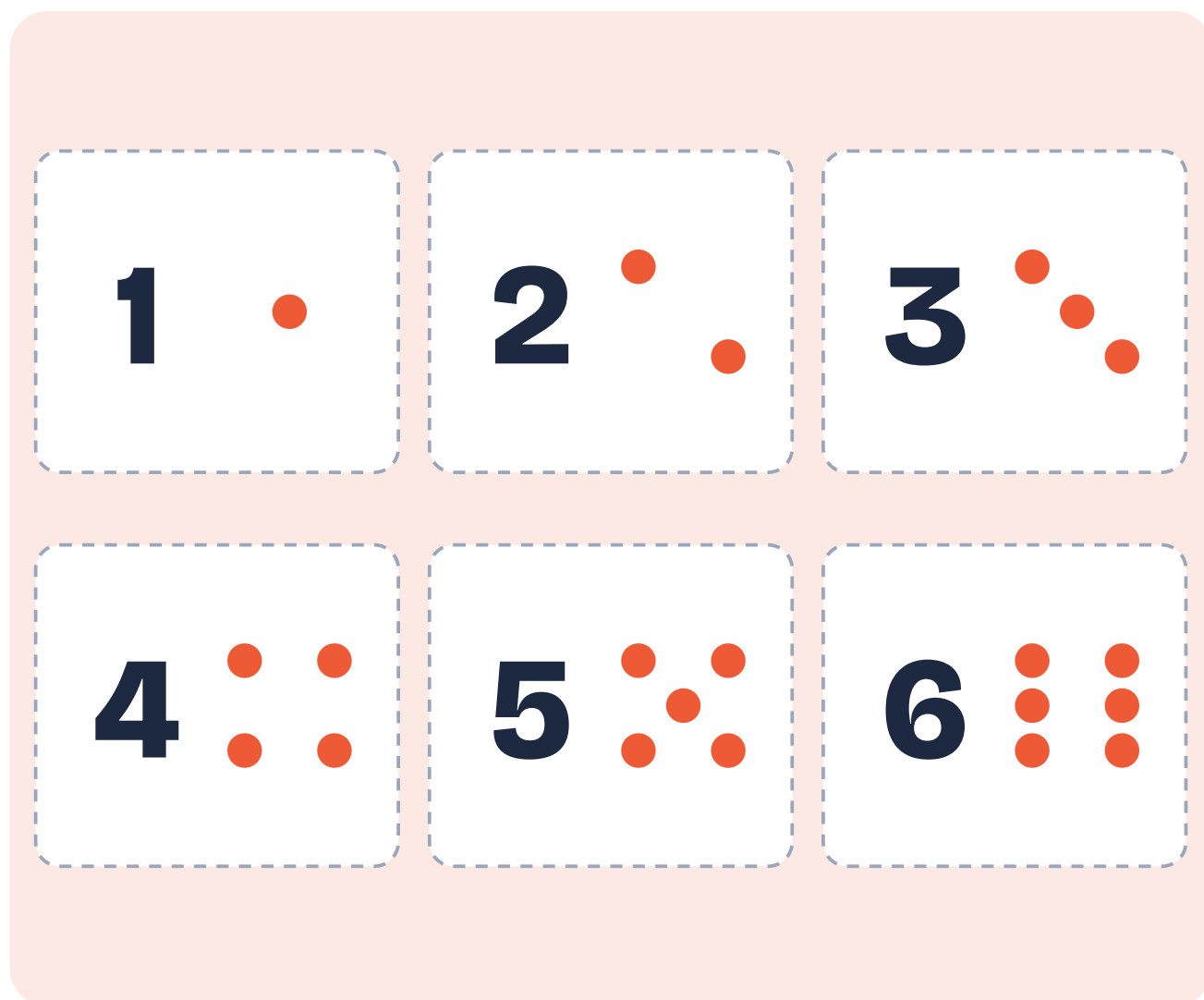
📍 3-5 years · from 42 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.



How many? Match 1 to 6

Count, then match. Count the pictures on a card, touching each one. Find the number with the same count of dots.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat

"One, two, three apples. Three! Three dots here too!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Use cards 1, 2 and 3 only.

MAKE IT HARDER

Line the cards up from 1 to 6, then count backwards.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

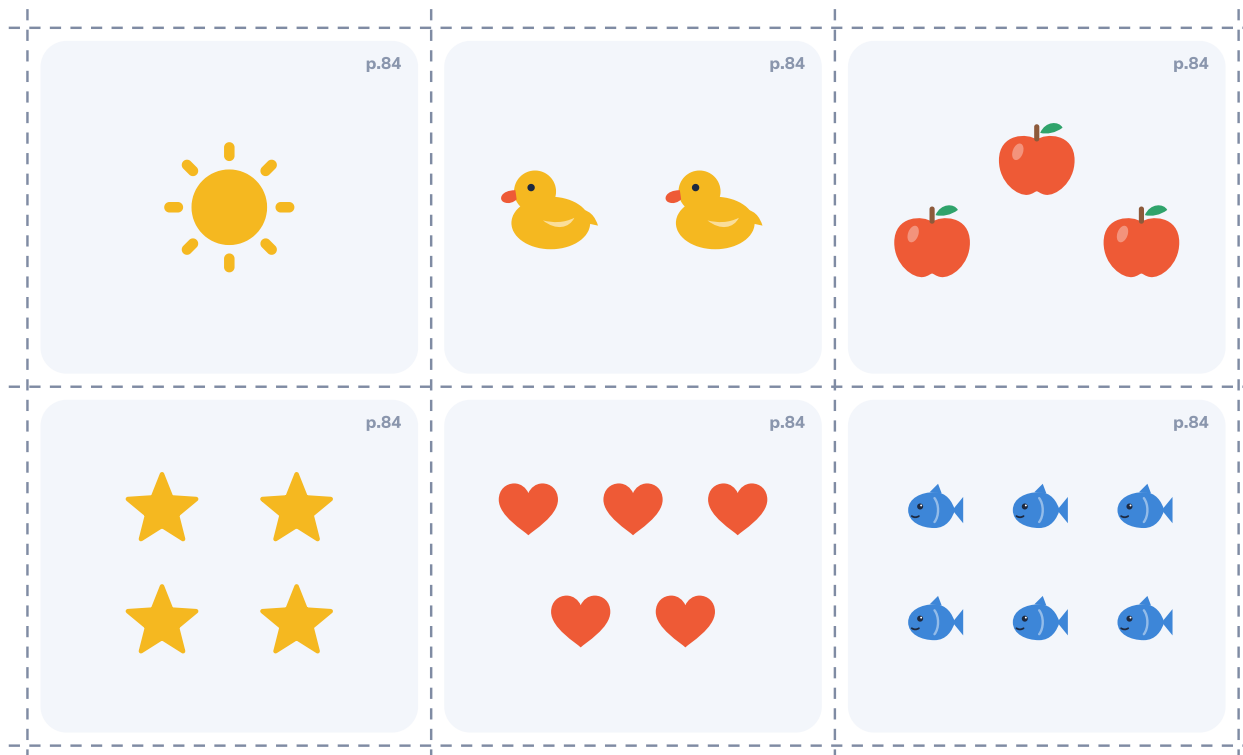
Count the ducks on one card. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 84: How many? Match 1 to 6

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



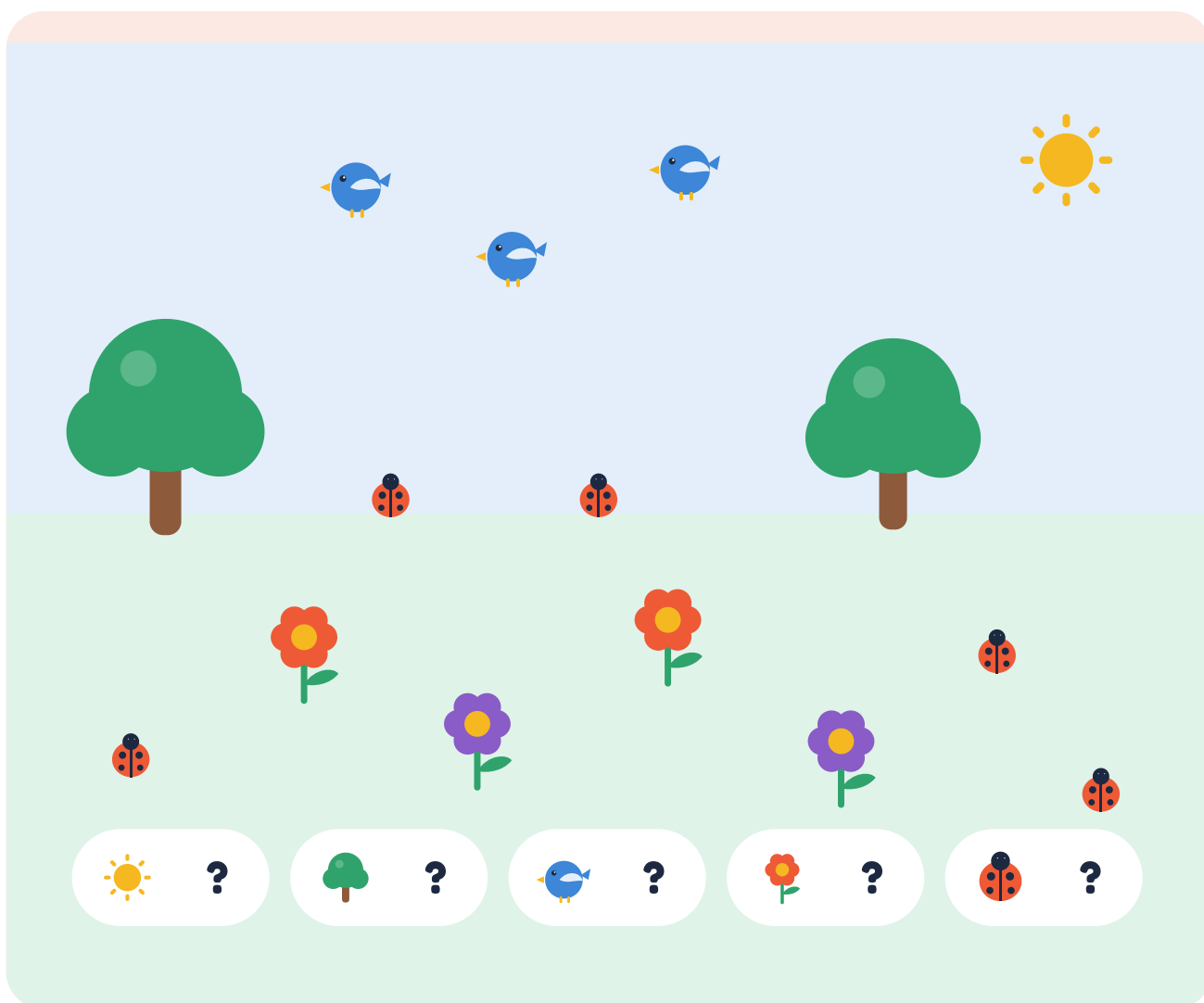
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Count in the garden

Look and count. Pick a picture from the strip at the bottom, then count how many are in the garden.



 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY** · Say what you see

"Let's count the ladybugs. One, two, three, four... five ladybugs!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Count the trees and the sun first: small numbers.

MAKE IT HARDER

Count everything with wings: birds and ladybugs!

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Count the trees. Done.

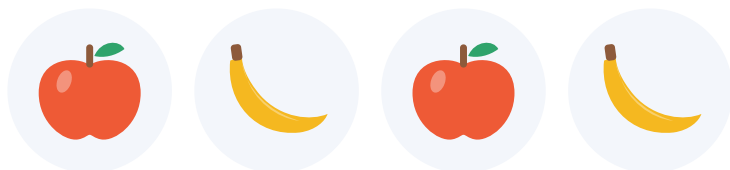
 **3-5 years** · from 40 months  **Prep: 0 min**  **Mess: None**  **Needs: Just this page**

 **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

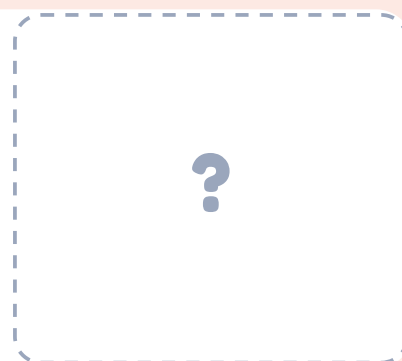
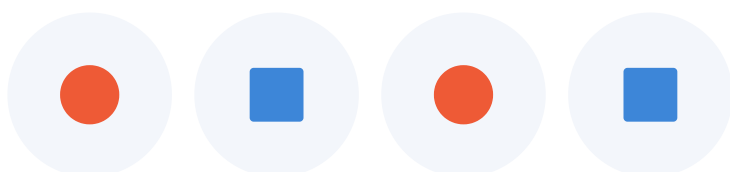
What comes next?

Say the pattern out loud. "Apple, banana, apple, banana..." The rhythm helps. Then find the card that comes next.

PATTERN 1



PATTERN 2



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Sing and gesture

"Apple, banana, apple, banana, (wait)... apple!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Say the pattern and clap it before looking for the card.

MAKE IT HARDER

Make your own pattern with spoons and cups.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Clap a pattern: clap, tap, clap, tap.

📍 3-5 years · from 42 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min (cards shared with page after) 💧 Mess: None

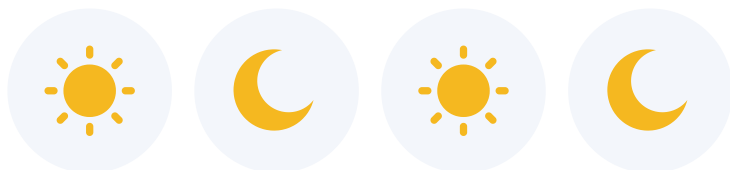
📦 Needs: The pattern cards (cut once)

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

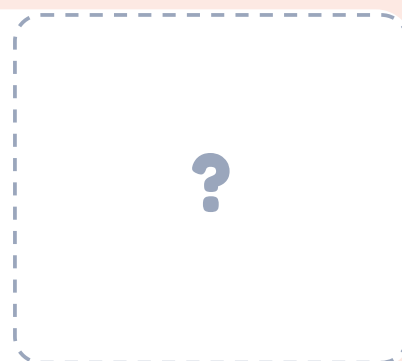
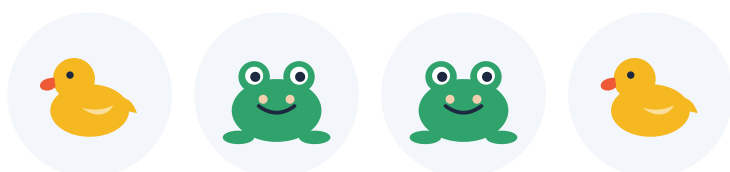
What comes next? Tricky ones

Say it, then find it. These patterns are longer. Point to each picture as you say it, then choose the next card.

PATTERN 3



PATTERN 4



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"Duck, frog, frog, duck, frog, (wait)... frog!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to page one's patterns, or build these with real toys.

MAKE IT HARDER

Make a pattern with three things: red, blue, yellow...

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Stomp a pattern: stomp, stomp, jump!

📍 3-5 years · from 4 years ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for the pattern pages (pages 87 and 88)

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



First, next, last

Tell the story in order. Find the three cards for each story. What happens first? Next? Last? Lay them in the boxes.

1 first**2 next****3 last****PLANT A SEED****1****2****3****BUILD A SNOWMAN****1****2****3****TALK WHILE YOU PLAY** · Say what you see**"First, a seed. Next, it grows. Last... a flower!"****MAKE IT EASIER**

Give the first card, then choose between two for "next."

MAKE IT HARDER

Tell the story back to you in their own words.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Tell one story with just your fingers: first, next, last.

📍 **3-5 years** · from 42 months ⌚ **Prep: 10 min** (one card sheet for both story pages) 💧 **Mess: None**

📁 **Needs: The story cards** (cut once)

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

First, next, last: more stories

Tell it, then do it. Put the pizza and bedtime stories in order. Tonight, say the bedtime steps together.

1 first**2 next****3 last**

MAKE A PIZZA

1**2****3**

BEDTIME

1**2****3****TALK WHILE YOU PLAY** · Offer a choice

"Pajamas or bath first? (wait) Bath first, then pajamas!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Just the bedtime story: it's the one they know best.

MAKE IT HARDER

Mix all four stories and sort them into rows.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Say tonight's bedtime steps in order: 1, 2, 3.

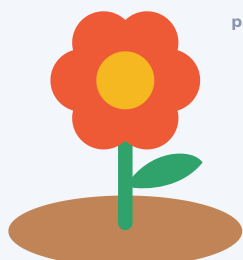
📍 3-5 years · from 44 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.



Pieces for the story pages (pages 90 and 91)

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



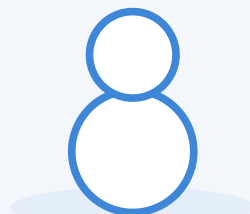
p.90+91

flower



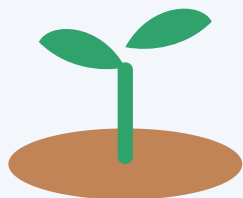
p.90+91

seed



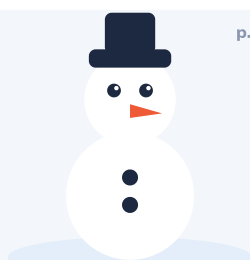
p.90+91

two balls



p.90+91

sprout



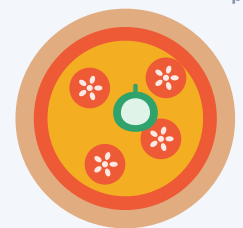
p.90+91

snowman



p.90+91

one ball



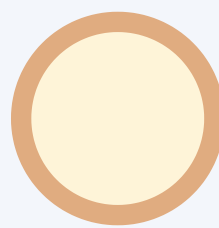
p.90+91

pizza



p.90+91

pajamas



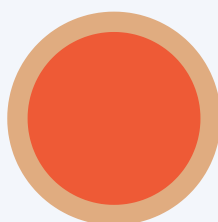
p.90+91

dough



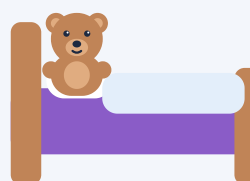
p.90+91

bath



p.90+91

sauce



p.90+91

bed



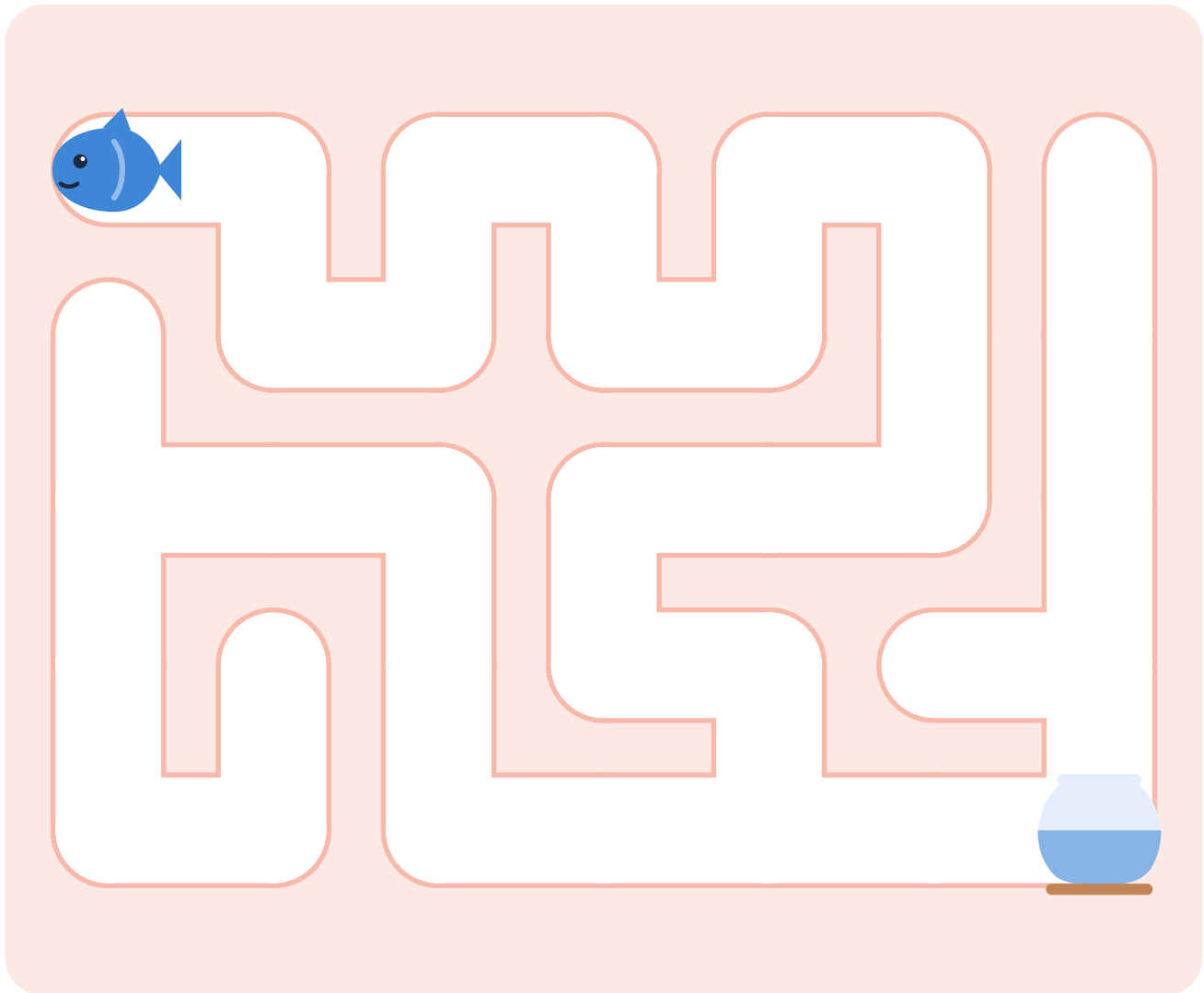
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Swim, Fish, swim!

Finger first. Trace the white path from Fish to its bowl. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"You found the way! Tell me where you turned."

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

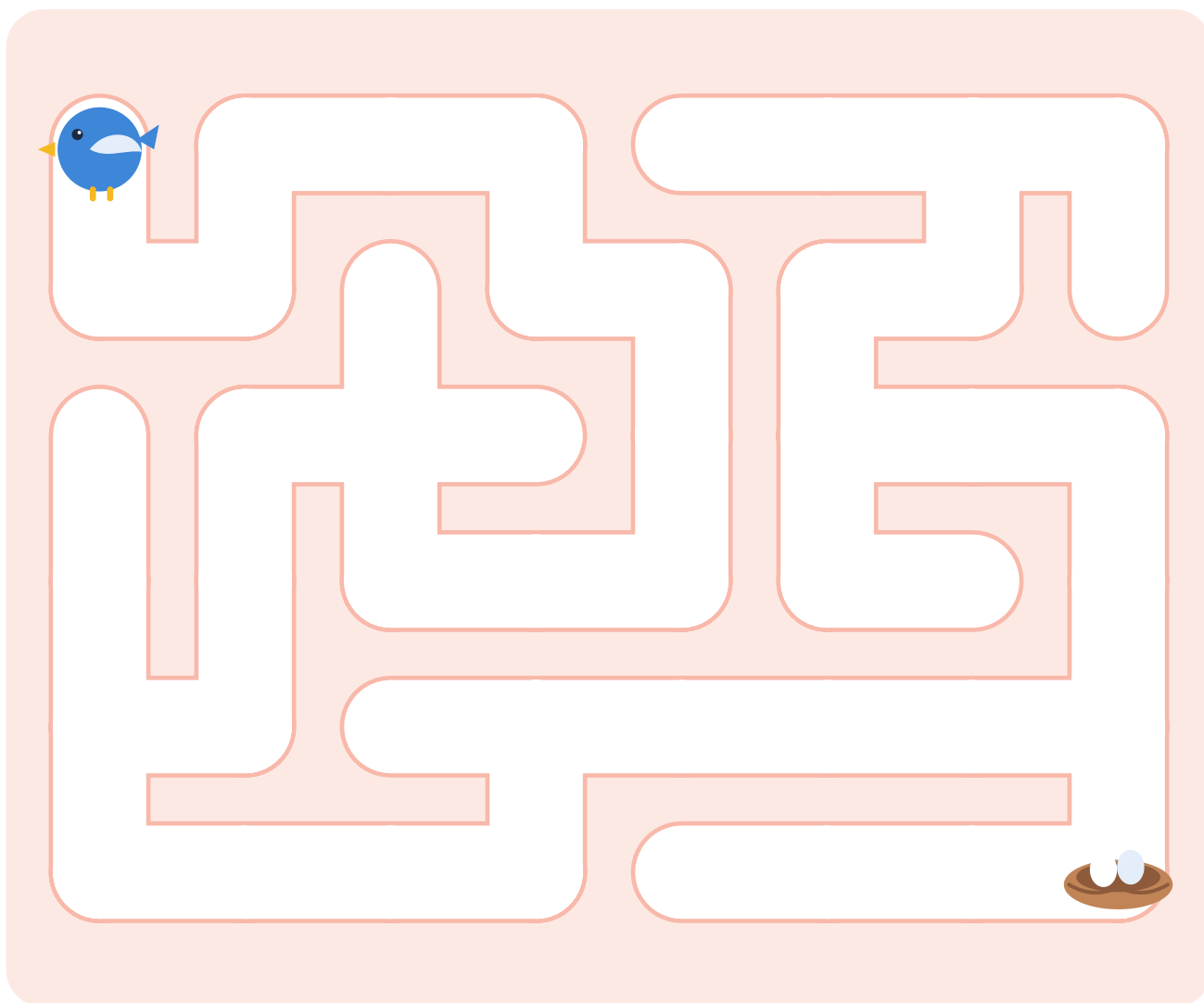
Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 44 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

 Play together, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Fly Bird to the nest

Finger first. Trace the white path from Bird to the nest. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Long path... short path... tweet, you did it!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3–5 years · from 4 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)



Play together, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Small, medium, big

Line them up. Find the smallest ball and put it first, then the medium one, then the biggest. Same for Teddy.

small	medium	big



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Small ball. Bigger ball. The BIGGEST ball!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Only small and big.

MAKE IT HARDER

Line up three real things: spoons, shoes, cups.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Find the biggest one. Done.

 3-5 years · from 38 months  Prep: 10 min  Mess: None  Needs: Scissors, cardstock

 **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 95: Small, medium, big

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



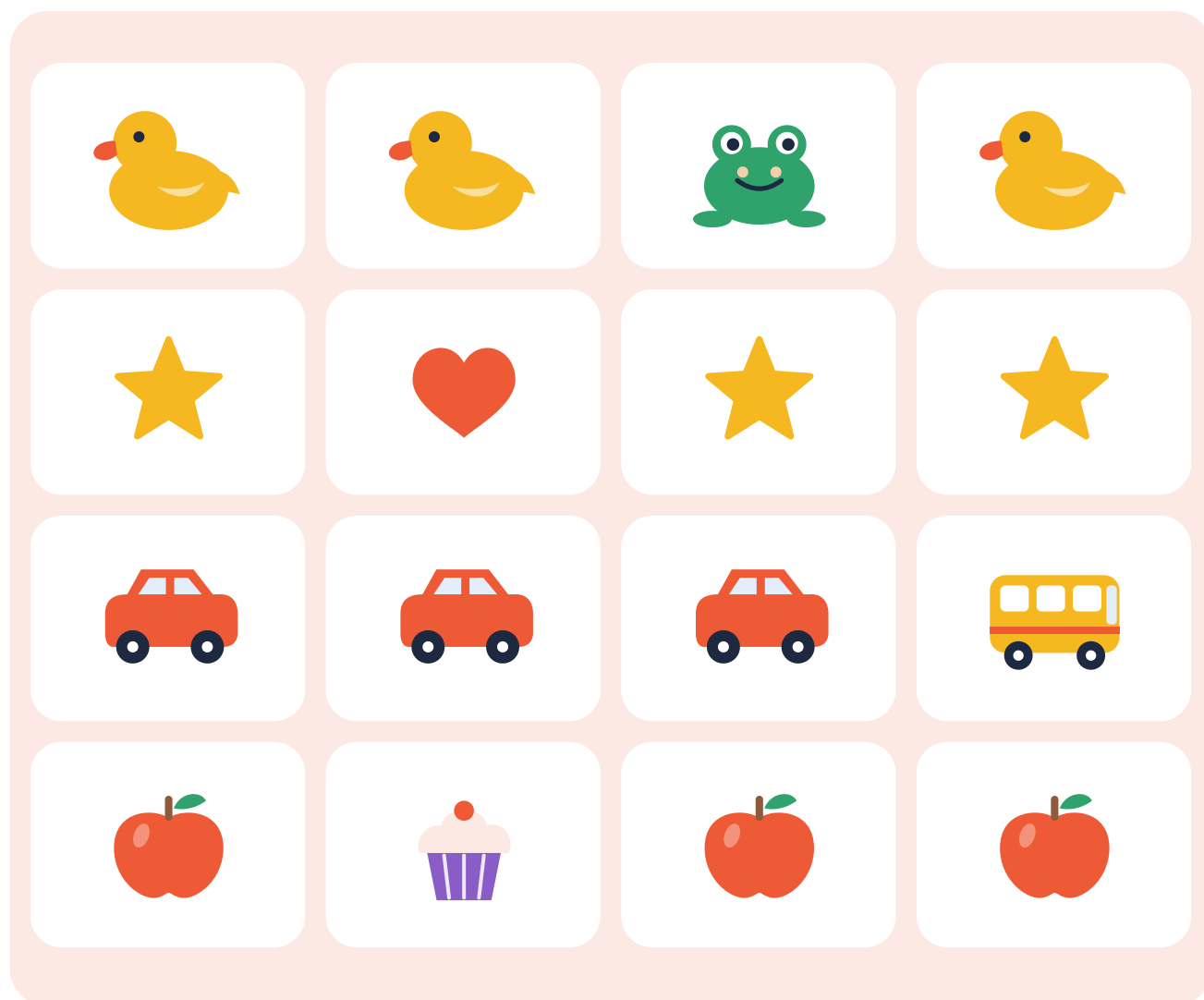
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Which one is different?

Spot the odd one out. Look along each row. Three are the same and one is different. Point to it and say why.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"That one! Why is it different? (wait) Yes, it's a frog!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Do the first row together and say what you see.

MAKE IT HARDER

Make your own row with three spoons and one sock.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

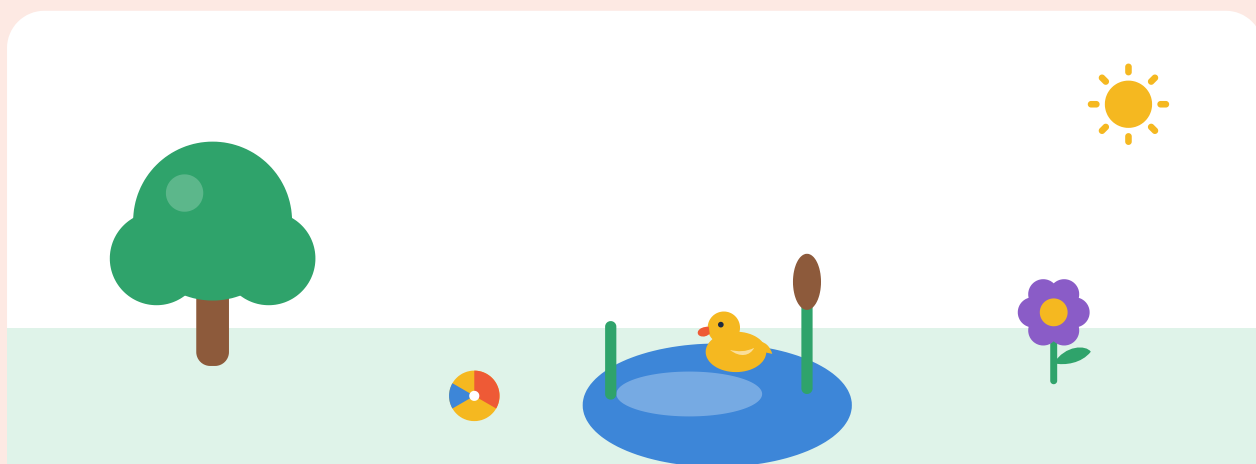
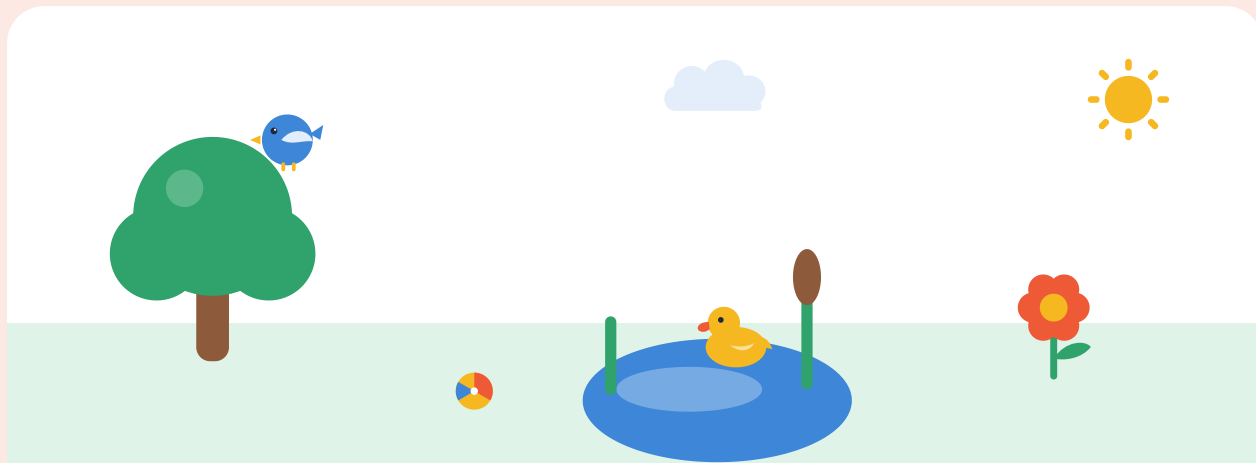
Do one row. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 40 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Spot 4 differences

Look top, then bottom. The two pictures look the same, but four things changed. Point to each one you find.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"The flower was red... now it's purple! That's one!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Give a hint: "Look at the sky."

MAKE IT HARDER

Tell what's different in words, then point to check.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Find one difference. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 44 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🧰 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Shopping trip

Read the list together. Point to each picture on the list, find that food card and put it in the basket.

Our list



apples



bread



milk



bananas

Basket



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Milk is on the list. Got it! What's next?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Just two things on the list: point and fetch.

MAKE IT HARDER

Swap roles: your child writes (draws) a list for you.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Fetch one thing from the list. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 99: Shopping trip

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



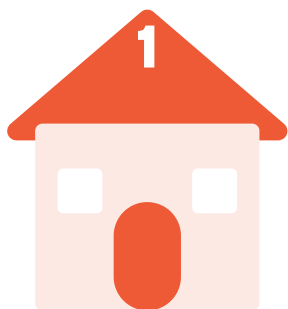
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Post office

Deliver the mail. Look at a letter's stamp color and number. Take it to the house with the same color door and number.



House
1



House
2



House
3



House
4



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"This one has a blue stamp. Is it for house 3 or house 1?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Match colors only; ignore the numbers.

MAKE IT HARDER

Knock-knock! Pretend to be the neighbor who opens the door.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Deliver one letter. Knock, knock. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 40 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 101: Post office

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

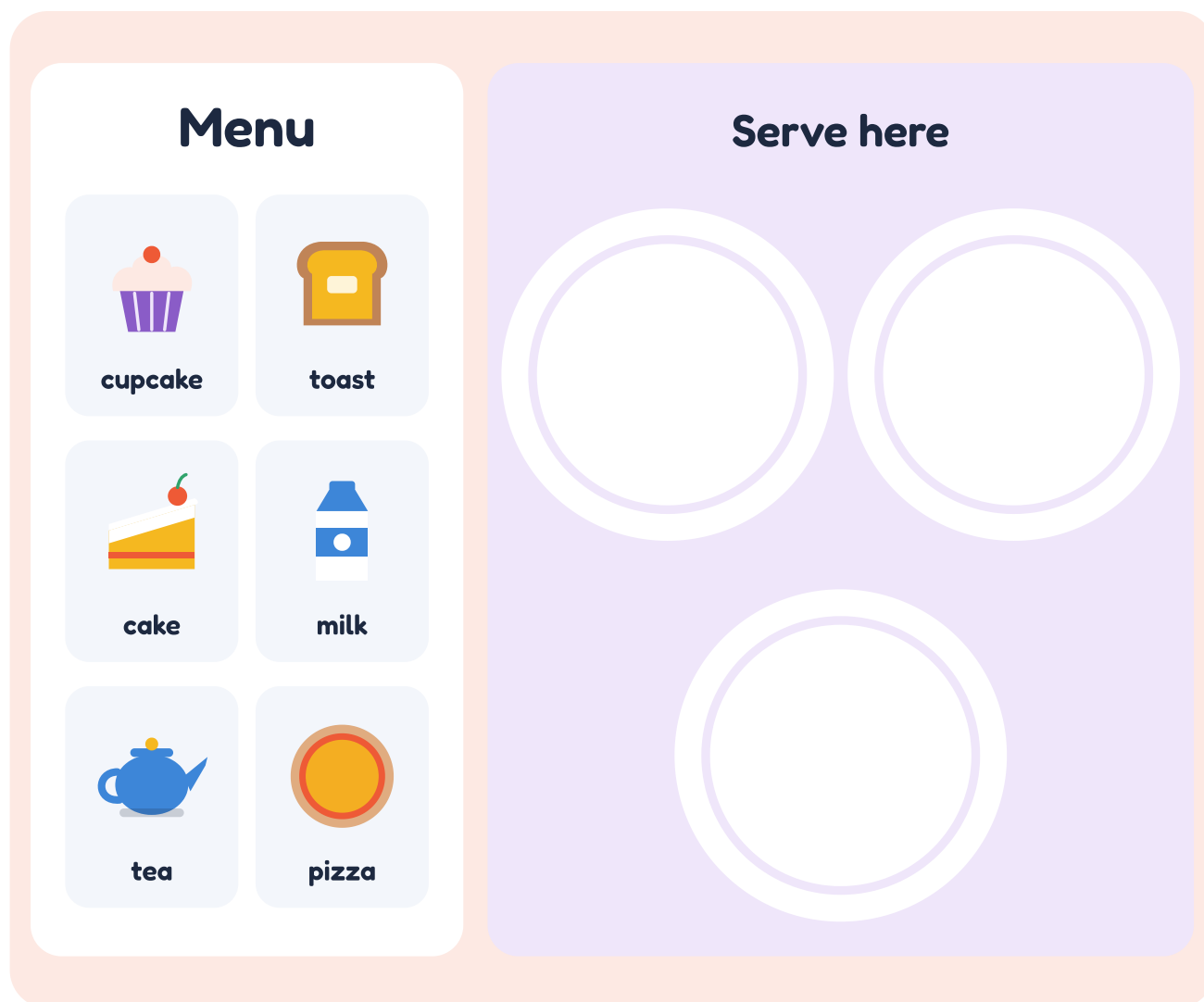


Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.

Our café

Take turns ordering. One of you orders from the menu; the other serves the cards onto the plates. Then swap.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Would you like toast or a cupcake today?"

MAKE IT EASIER

One plate, one order, lots of "yum!"

MAKE IT HARDER

Take three orders and remember them all.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Order one thing. Pretend to sip tea. Done.

 3-5 years · from 3 years  Prep: 10 min  Mess: None  Needs: Scissors, cardstock

 **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 103: Our café

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



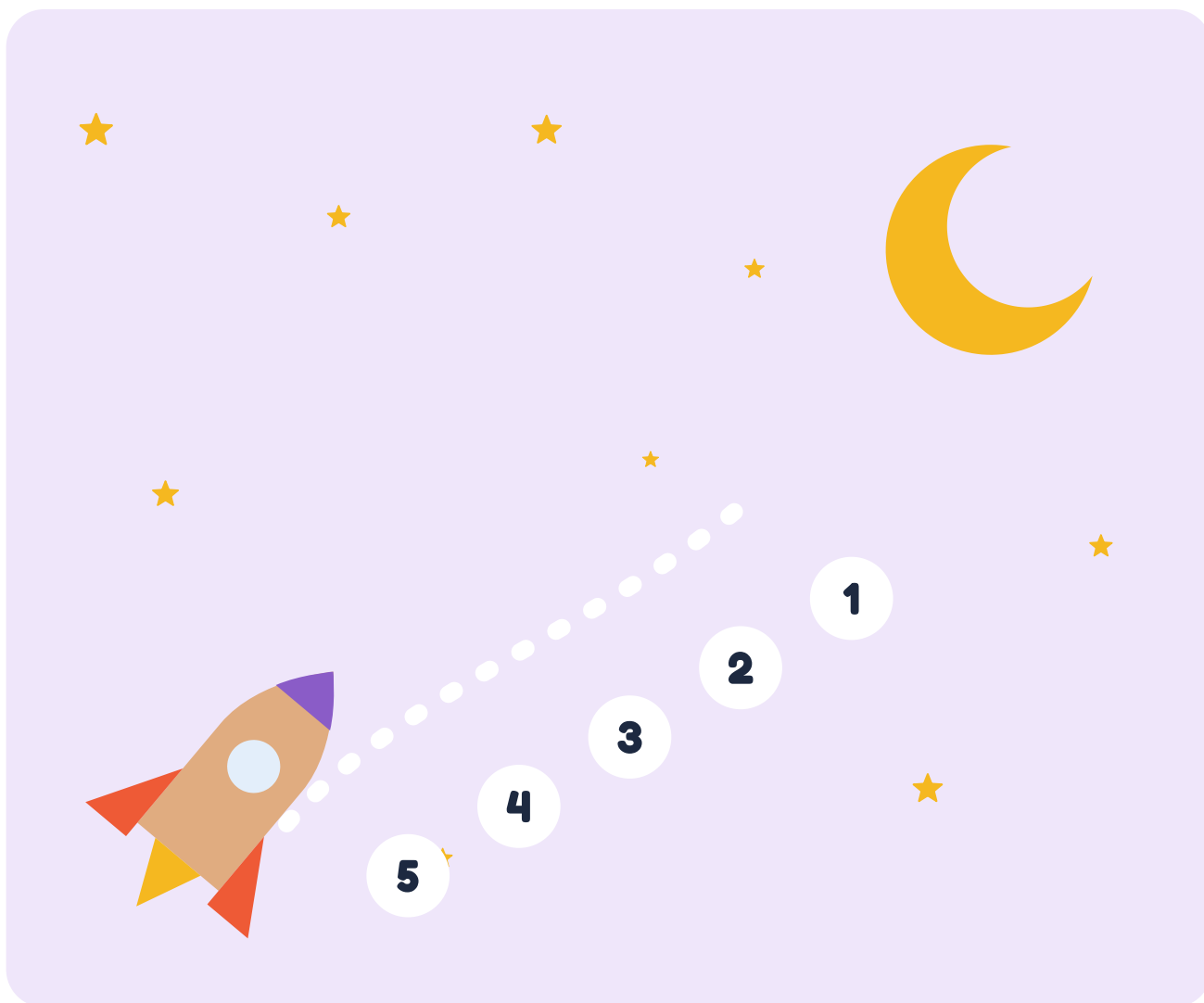
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Blast off to the moon

Count down and fly. Crouch down low together, count down from 5, and jump up on “blast off!” Fly a finger to the moon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"5, 4, 3, 2, 1... (wait) BLAST OFF!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Count down from 3.

MAKE IT HARDER

Plan the trip: "What will we pack?
Who's coming?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Count down from 5 with your fingers.
Whoosh!

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



Drive around town

Drive a finger (or a big toy car). Visit each place in town. At every stop, say where you are and what you'll do there.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"Where to next? The café! Beep beep. What will you order?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Drive from home to the park and back.

MAKE IT HARDER

Give directions: "Turn at the pond, stop at the shop."

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

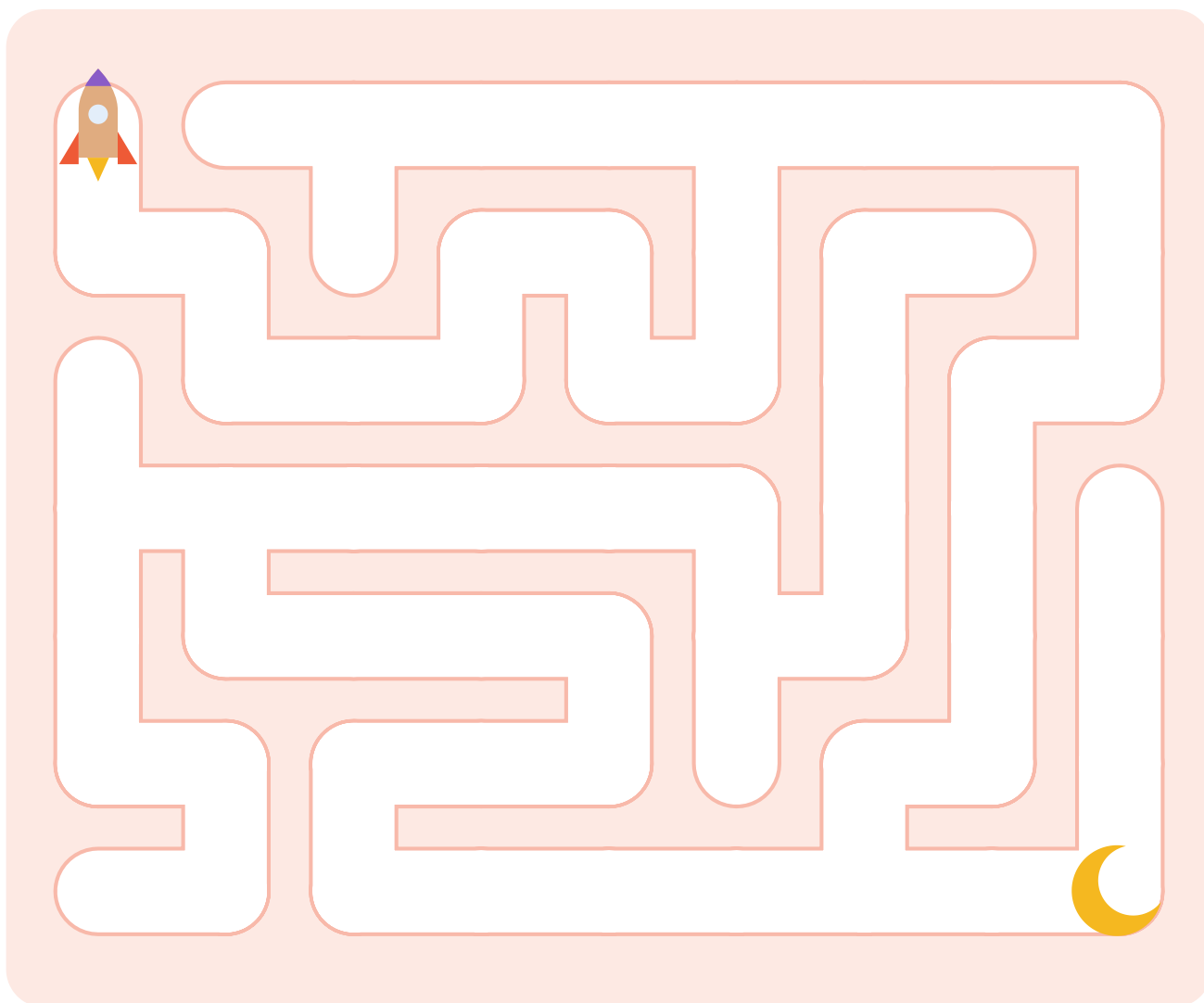
Drive home. Beep. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Toy cars for younger brothers and sisters must be bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

Rocket to the moon

Finger first. Trace the white path from the rocket to the moon. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Pause and wait

"3, 2, 1... (wait) blast off! Which way to the moon?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Try the next maze, or do this one backwards, from the end to the start.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 54 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Rhyme time

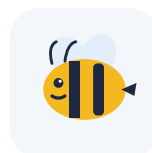
Listen for the rhyme. Say both words slowly: "cat... hat." They sound alike at the end. Find each picture's rhyming friend.

**cat**

rhymes with...

**moon**

rhymes with...

**bee**

rhymes with...

**car**

rhymes with...

**fish**

rhymes with...

**frog**

rhymes with...

**TALK WHILE YOU PLAY** · Sing and gesture**"Cat, hat! Moon, spoon! Frog... (wait) log!"****MAKE IT EASIER**

Say two choices: "Cat... hat or spoon?"

MAKE IT HARDER

Make up silly rhymes: cat, hat, splat, zat!

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Say one rhyme pair and laugh. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 42 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 108: Rhyme time

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



Where does it go?

Tidy up the house. Pick a card and ask "Where does this live?" Put it in the kitchen, bathroom or bedroom.



kitchen



bathroom



bedroom



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Offer a choice

"Toothbrush: kitchen or bathroom? (wait) Bathroom!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Two rooms only: kitchen and bedroom.

MAKE IT HARDER

Walk to the real rooms and find one thing in each.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Put one card in the right room.

📍 3-5 years · from 40 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛠 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 110: Where does it go?

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.

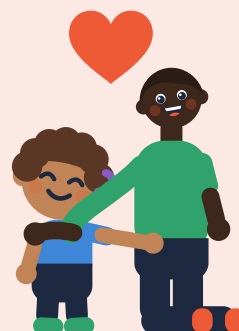


How do they feel?

Read the faces. Look at each picture. How does the child feel? How can you tell? What might happen next?



surprised?



loved?



amazed?



sleepy?



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Uh-oh, the cup fell. She looks surprised. What would you do?"

MAKE IT EASIER

Just name the feeling: happy, surprised, sleepy.

MAKE IT HARDER

Tell a time you felt that way.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Pick one picture and make that face.

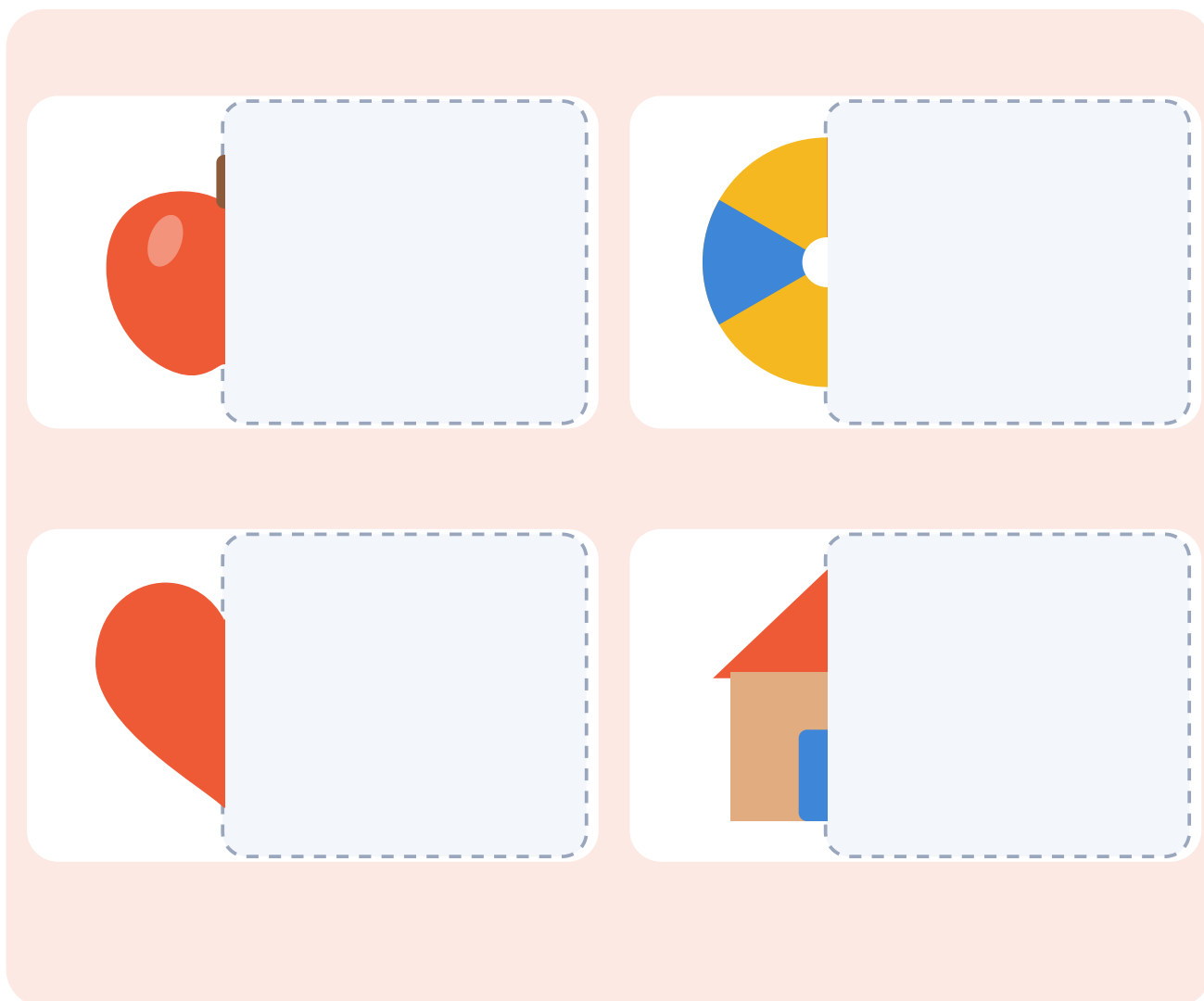
📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.



Finish the picture

Find the other half. Each picture is missing its right side. Find the card that finishes it and slide it into the box.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Half an apple... where's the other half? There! A whole apple!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Give two cards to choose from.

MAKE IT HARDER

Cover half of a real toy with a cloth:
"What is it?"

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

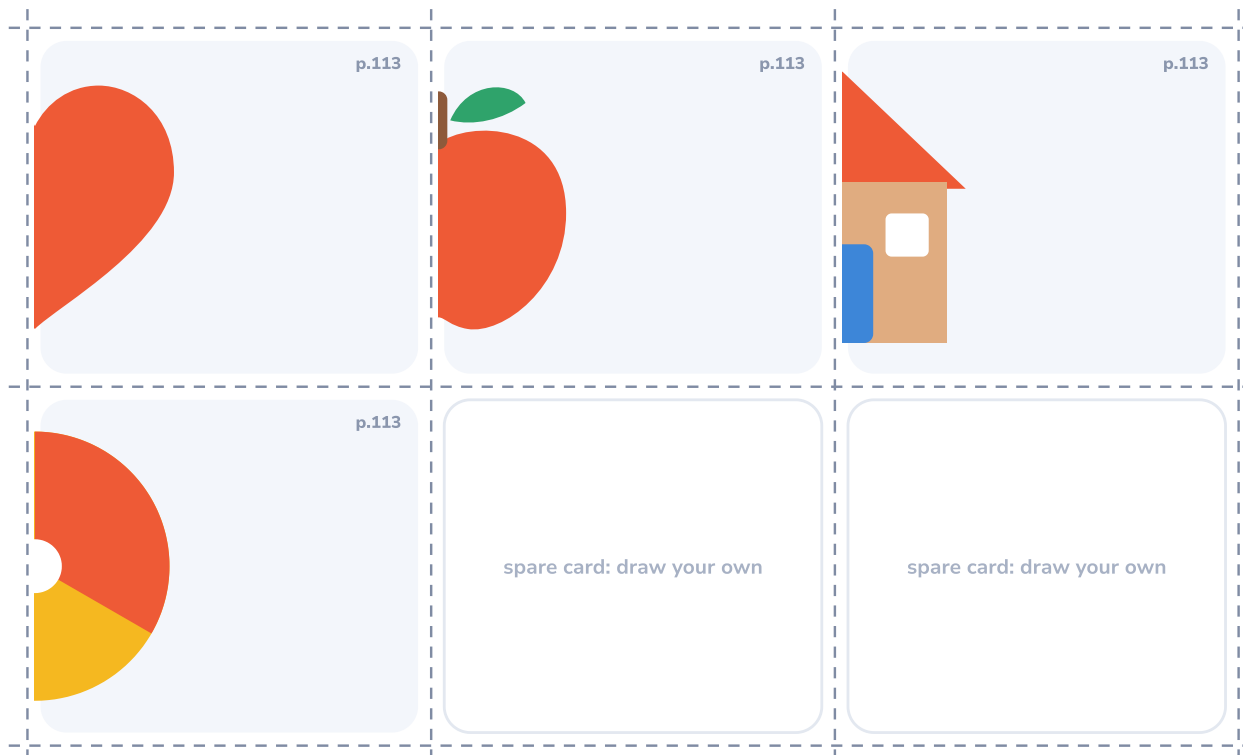
Finish one picture. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 42 months ⌚ Prep: 10 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Scissors, cardstock

✅ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. **Grown-up keeps the pieces** and counts them back in. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**, and keep pieces away from under-3s.

Pieces for page 113: Finish the picture

✂ Cut on the dashed lines: straight cuts only. Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger: bigger than a toilet-paper tube.



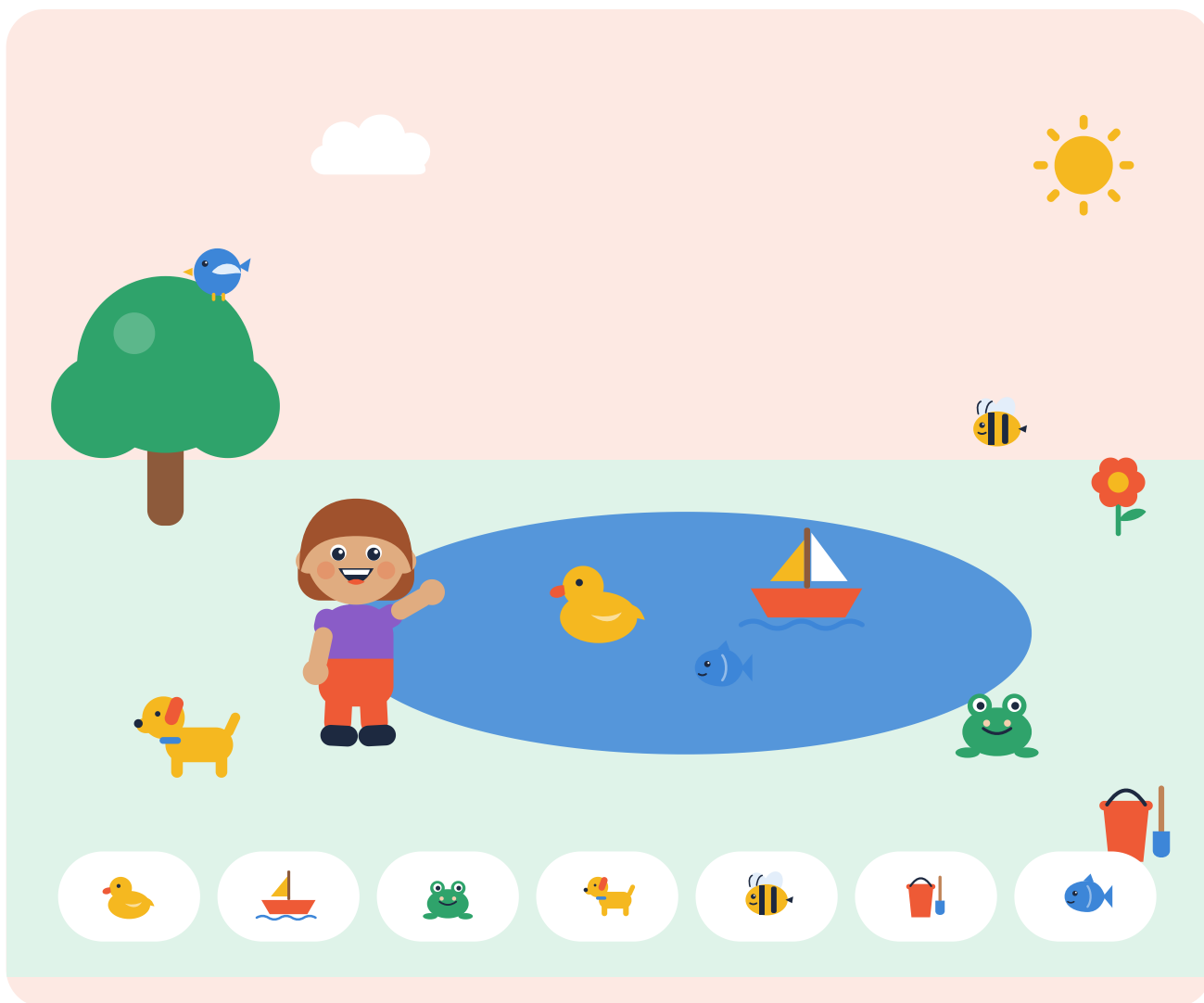
Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. Velcro is optional: **check dots before each play**; throw away any piece whose dot lifts.



I spy at the pond

Play I spy. Pick a picture from the strip and say "I spy something..." with one clue. Your child finds it in the big picture.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"I spy something yellow that says quack!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Point to a strip picture, then find it together.

MAKE IT HARDER

Your child gives the clues and you guess.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

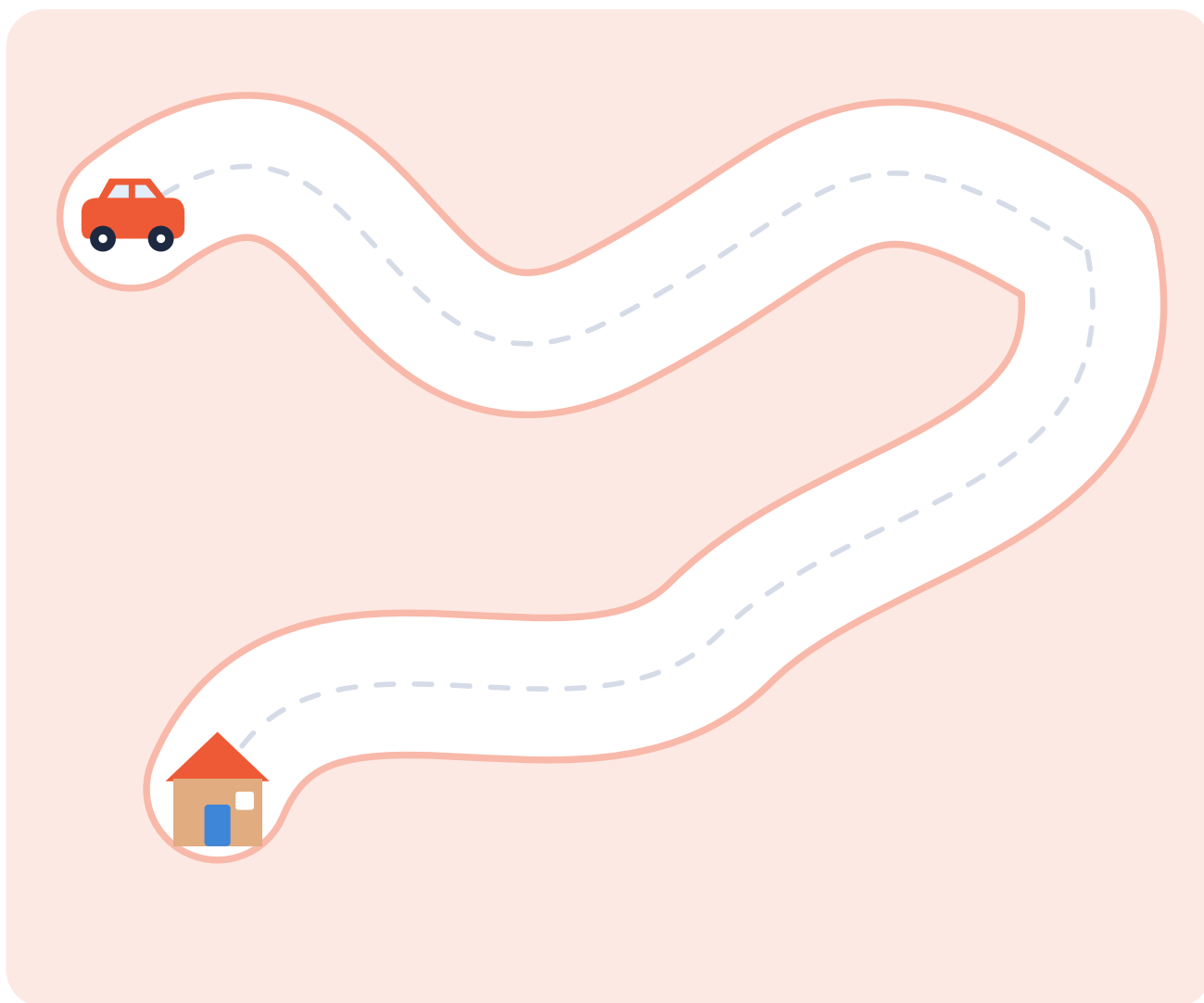
Find the duck. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📦 Needs: Just this page

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there.

Wiggly road

Stay on the road. Drive a finger from start to finish without leaving the road. On a laminated page, use a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Wiggle, wiggle, curve... you made it!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Slow and steady: say "slow" as you go.

MAKE IT HARDER

Trace it with your other hand, or with eyes closed and a grown-up guiding.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

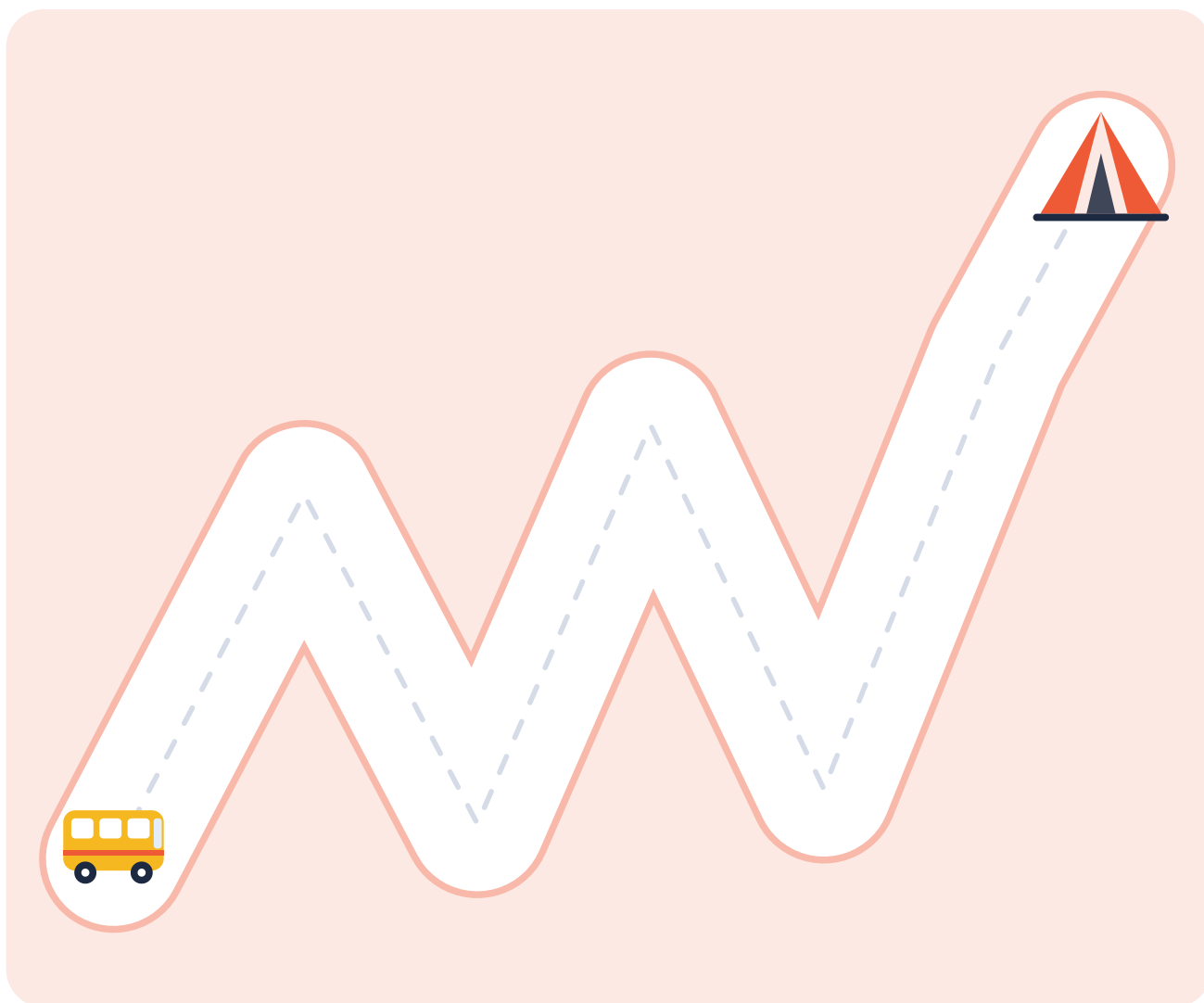
Drive it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 3 years ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

Zig-zag mountain road

Stay on the road. Drive a finger from start to finish without leaving the road. On a laminated page, use a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Up the hill, down the hill, zig, zag!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Slow and steady: say "slow" as you go.

MAKE IT HARDER

Trace it with your other hand, or with eyes closed and a grown-up guiding.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Drive it once with a finger. Done.

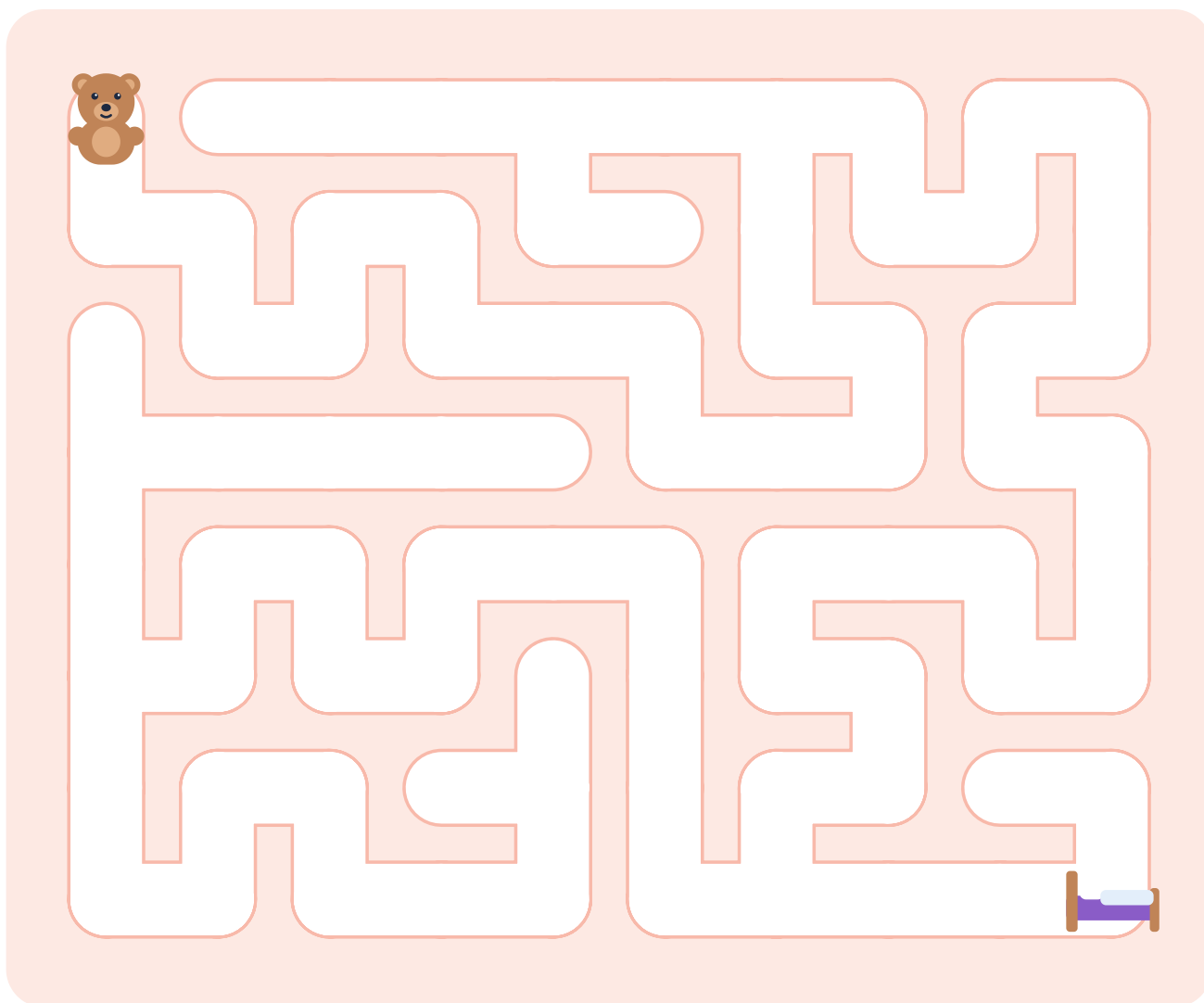
📍 3-5 years · from 40 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 📁 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.



Teddy's long way to bed

Finger first. Trace the white path from Teddy to bed. On a laminated page, try again with a dry-erase crayon.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

"You're the guide. Tell Teddy where to go!"

MAKE IT EASIER

Go back to an easier maze, or trace the path together first.

MAKE IT HARDER

Time to draw your own maze for a grown-up to solve!

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

Trace it once with a finger. Done.

📍 3-5 years · from 54 months ⌚ Prep: 0 min 💧 Mess: None 🛒 Needs: Just this page (dry-erase crayon optional)

✓ **Play together**, with a grown-up right there. Grown-up keeps crayon caps. Pages go back in the book when play ends.

My people

Tape a photo in each frame. Photos of the people your child loves make great first words. Every family is different: type your own names on the next page.



photo here

Mama



photo here

Dada



photo here

Grandma



photo here

Grandpa



photo here

me!



photo here

our dog



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Who's that? It's Grandma! Hi, Grandma! (wave)"



Play together. Photos stay taped flat under the lamination or sheet protector. No pins, clips or loose photo corners for under-3s.



My people

Type the names, print, then tape in photos. Use any names your family uses: Mom, Ima, Abuela, Nonno, Auntie, our cat...

A large light green rounded rectangle contains six white rounded rectangles arranged in two rows of three. Each white rectangle has a dashed blue border and the text "photo here" in the center.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Say what you see

"Who's that? It's Grandma! Hi, Grandma! (wave)"



Play together. Photos stay taped flat under the lamination or sheet protector. No pins, clips or loose photo corners for under-3s.



Our words

Type or write a word your child loves, then draw it, stick a picture from a magazine, or tape a photo above it.

draw or stick it here	draw or stick it here	draw or stick it here
draw or stick it here	draw or stick it here	draw or stick it here



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Repeat and add one word

"Truck! Big truck. Big red truck!"



Play together. Glue and stickers are for grown-up hands on this page; let it dry before little ones play.



Our matching game

Draw the same picture twice: once in a box here and once on the matching card on the next page. Type labels first if you like.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · Follow their lead

“You drew a cat! Where’s the other cat?”

MAKE IT EASIER

Draw just two or three pairs.

MAKE IT HARDER

Your child draws; you guess, then match.

TIRED? 2-MINUTE VERSION

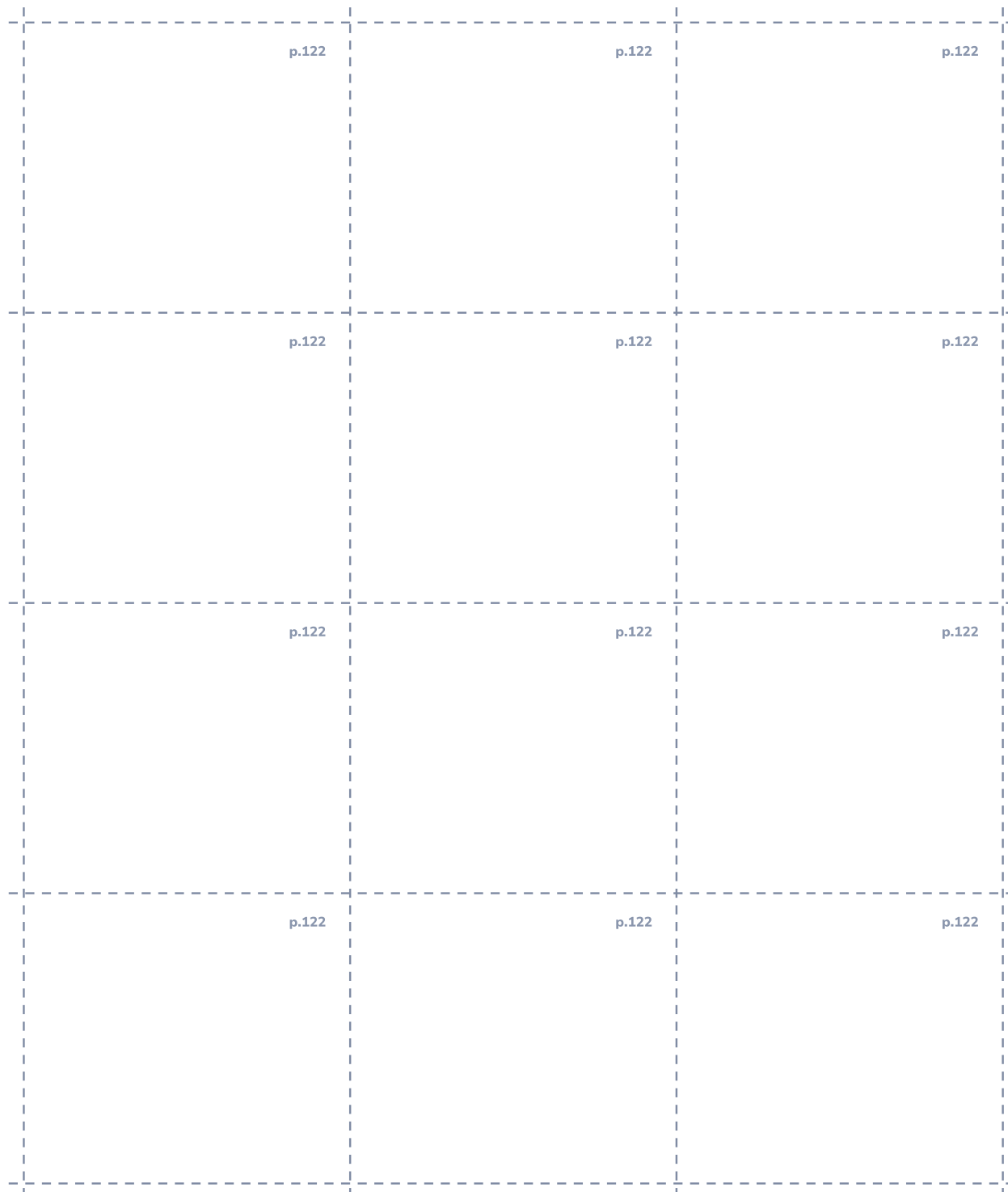
Draw one picture together. Done.

✓ **Play together.** Grown-up keeps the pieces. Pieces are 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger. No velcro dots for under-3s.



Blank cards for your own games

 Draw, stick or type, then cut on the dashed lines. Every card is 2.25 × 2 in (5.7 × 5.1 cm).



Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in; store them in a labeled pouch. No velcro dots for under-3s.



This week's busy book

An example week for a 1-2-year-old: one page a day, with a favorite on repeat.

	PAGE TO PLAY	TALK LINE TO TRY	PLAYED?
Monday	Same, same! Toys • p.28	"Ball! Same ball!"	☐
Tuesday	Who says "moo"? • p.25	"The cow says... moo!"	☐
Wednesday	"up" • p.22	"Up... up... UP!"	☐
Thursday	Same, same! Toys • p.28	Again! Favorites repeat.	☐
Friday	Peekaboo house • p.40	"Where's dog? Peekaboo!"	☐
Saturday	Drum along! • p.32	"Boom! Boom!"	☐
Sunday	Lunch for Teddy • p.34	"Toast for Teddy? Yum!"	☐

Rotate, don't rush

Keep this week's pages in the binder and the rest on a shelf. Next week, swap two pages and keep the favorites.

OUR FAVORITE PAGE THIS WEEK

Same, same! Toys

This week's busy book

An example week for a 1-2-year-old: one page a day, with a favorite on repeat.

	PAGE TO PLAY	TALK LINE TO TRY	PLAYED?
Sunday	Lunch for Teddy · p.34	"Toast for Teddy? Yum!"	☐
Monday	Same, same! Toys · p.28	"Ball! Same ball!"	☐
Tuesday	Who says "moo"? · p.25	"The cow says... moo!"	☐
Wednesday	"up" · p.22	"Up... up... UP!"	☐
Thursday	Same, same! Toys · p.28	Again! Favorites repeat.	☐
Friday	Peekaboo house · p.40	"Where's dog? Peekaboo!"	☐
Saturday	Drum along! · p.32	"Boom! Boom!"	☐

Rotate, don't rush

Keep this week's pages in the binder and the rest on a shelf. Next week, swap two pages and keep the favorites.

OUR FAVORITE PAGE THIS WEEK

Same, same! Toys

This week's busy book

Pick 3–5 pages for the week. Repeats are great. Type in before printing, or write by hand.

	PAGE TO PLAY	TALK LINE TO TRY	PLAYED?
Monday			☐
Tuesday			☐
Wednesday			☐
Thursday			☐
Friday			☐
Saturday			☐
Sunday			☐

Rotate, don't rush

Keep this week's pages in the binder and the rest on a shelf. Next week, swap two pages and keep the favorites.

OUR FAVORITE PAGE THIS WEEK



This week's busy book

Pick 3–5 pages for the week. Repeats are great. Type in before printing, or write by hand.

	PAGE TO PLAY	TALK LINE TO TRY	PLAYED?
Sunday			☐
Monday			☐
Tuesday			☐
Wednesday			☐
Thursday			☐
Friday			☐
Saturday			☐

Rotate, don't rush

Keep this week's pages in the binder and the rest on a shelf. Next week, swap two pages and keep the favorites.

OUR FAVORITE PAGE THIS WEEK



hooray for

Busy Book Star

for playing, pointing, matching and talking together!



FAVORITE PAGE

DATE

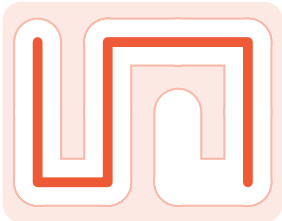


Play Before Pixels

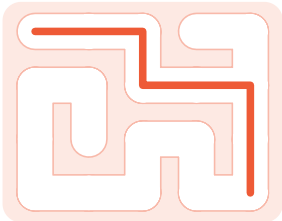
Snap a photo for the fridge or the grandparents. Version 1.0 · September 2026

Peek only if you need to

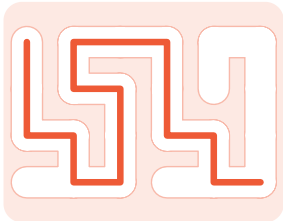
There's no wrong way to play. These are here for grown-ups who like to check.



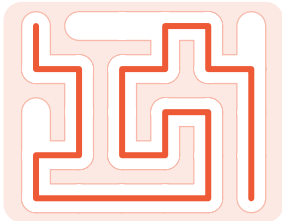
p.80 Help Duck get to the pond



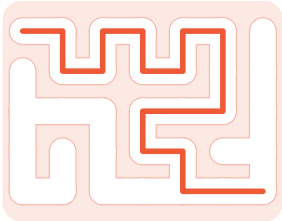
p.81 Help Dog get home



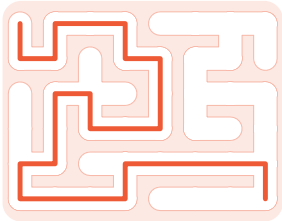
p.82 Help Bee find the flower



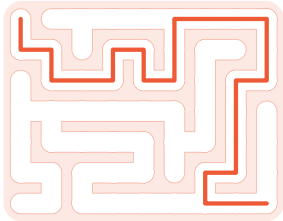
p.83 Drive the car home



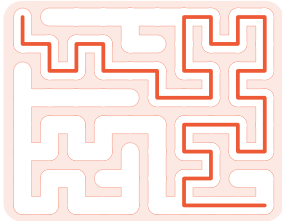
p.93 Swim, Fish, swim!



p.94 Fly Bird to the nest



p.107 Rocket to the moon



p.118 Teddy's long way to bed

70	Who lives here?	dog: doghouse · fish: fishbowl · bird: nest · bee: hive · duck: pond · teddy: bed
86	Count in the garden	1 sun, 2 trees, 3 birds, 4 flowers, 5 ladybugs
87	What comes next?	Pattern 1: apple · Pattern 2: circle
88	What comes next? Tricky ones	Pattern 3: sun · Pattern 4: frog
90	First, next, last	Seed → sprout → flower · one ball → two balls → snowman
91	First, next, last: more stories	Dough → sauce → pizza · bath → pajamas → bed
97	Which one is different?	Row 1: frog · Row 2: heart · Row 3: bus · Row 4: cupcake
98	Spot 4 differences	Cloud gone · bird gone · flower red → purple · ball bigger
108	Rhyme time	cat-hat · moon-spoon · bee-tree · car-star · fish-dish · frog-log
110	Where does it go?	Kitchen: teapot, pot, spoon · Bathroom: toothbrush, towel, bubbles · Bedroom: teddy, lamp, pajamas

Questions, answered

What ages is it for?

About 12 months to 5 years, in three bands (1–2, 2–3, 3–5). Every page shows its starting age in months. Move up or down freely.

Do I have to cut everything?

No. 49 activities need no cutting at all. Cut piece sheets when you have ten minutes; each has straight cuts only and 12 pieces or fewer.

Are the pieces safe for my toddler?

Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger, bigger than a toilet-paper tube. A grown-up plays along, keeps the pieces and checks them each time. No velcro dots for under-3s.

Which file should I print?

US Letter or A4 to match your paper. Color for bright pages; Low-ink for white pages with colorable line art. Print at 100% / actual size.

Can I type into the pages?

Yes: the make-your-own pages, binder covers, labels, planner and certificate have type-in boxes that work in free PDF readers. Type, save, then print.

Do I need a laminator?

No. Sheet protectors or plain cardstock work well. Laminating just makes pieces last longer (tips on page 9).

Is anything shipped?

No, it's a digital download. You print at home or at a print shop, as many copies as your own family needs.

My child only wants one page. Is that OK?

Completely. Most children love two or three pages and repeat them. Try that page's "harder" line when it feels easy.

Is this a lesson plan or a program?

No. It's play for families: pages to talk about together, with no tests or scores. It isn't medical or professional advice. Questions about development go to your pediatrician.

Can I use it with a group or class?

This copy is for your own home. For a child-care, classroom or library license, send us a message through the shop.

Can I share it with a friend?

Please share a photo of your busy book, not the files. If a friend would like a copy, they can buy their own; it keeps new pages coming.

Is it only in English?

The printed words are in English. Say every word, talk line and rhyme in the language you know best; any language works. Type your family's own words on the make-your-own pages (p.120–121).

Can I give it as a gift?

Yes. Print it, slip the pages into a binder with a cover in their favorite color and give it ready to play. Please give the printed book, not the files.

A file won't open on my phone

Etsy downloads work best in a web browser on a computer or tablet (the app can't download files). Send us a message through the shop if you're stuck.

Next for your child's age

Made to go together: the same friendly characters, the same talk-while-you-play idea.



Up! Go! More!

Our talk-along first-words book, ages 0–3. The first-words pages in this busy book come from it.



100 Screen-Free Plays

Plays for ages 0–5 with things you already have, sorted by age, each with a talk line.



150 "I'm Bored" Play Cards

Play ideas for ages 1–12, sorted by age and energy, with a talk prompt on every card.

Find them in the Play Before Pixels shop. Printables download instantly; books are printed to order.

THANK YOU

Thank you for playing with us

We hope a few of these pages become favorites. If they do, a review in the shop helps other families find us.

Share the fun

Snap a photo of your busy book or the Busy Book Star certificate and share it with friends and family. Sharing is always optional; please don't share the files themselves.

